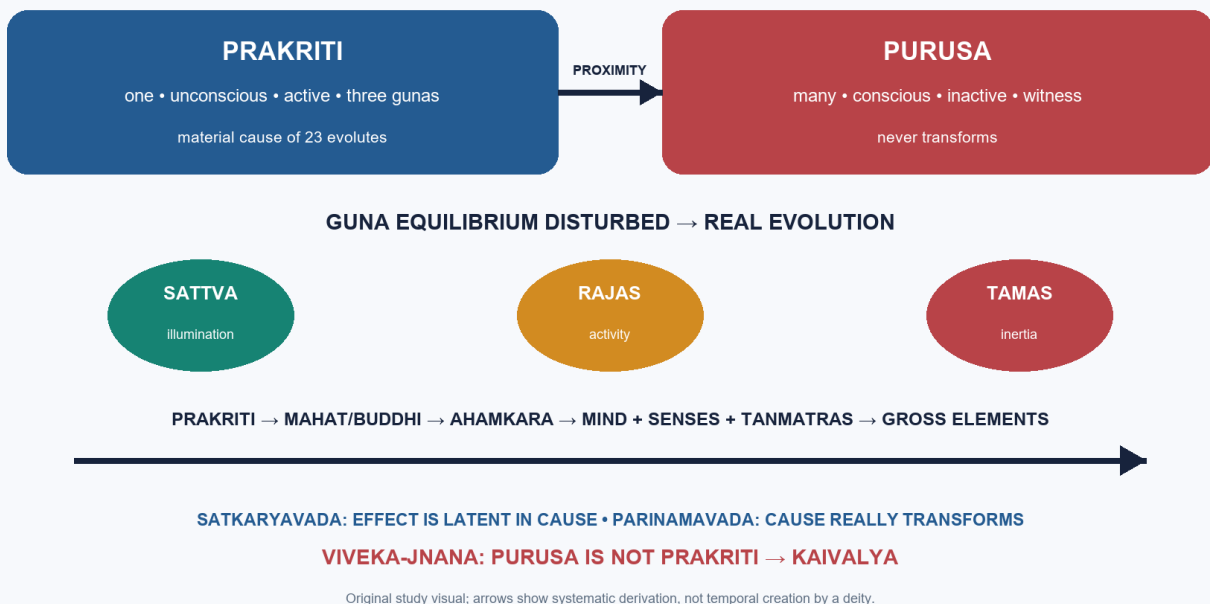


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

SAMKHYA - Layered Complete Learning Session - Syllabus Item 16

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

SAMKHYA: ONE PRAKRITI, THREE GUNAS, MANY PURUSAS



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

SAMKHYA - Layered Complete Learning Session - Syllabus Item 16

Syllabus (verbatim): Samkhya; Prakrit; Purusa; Causation; Liberation. **Evidence key:** FACT: canonical doctrine · ANALYSIS: analytical synthesis · CAUTION: contested **Placement:** A compact syllabus clause with very high conversion into 10-, 15- and 20-mark questions because it connects metaphysics, cosmology, causation, selfhood, liberation and Śaṅkara's anti-Sāṃkhya critique.

How to use this layered session

Every logical subtopic follows the Philosophy five-layer sequence:

Layer	Purpose
1. SIMPLE START	Plain-language visual gateway
2. CORE UPSC	Complete retained doctrine, terminology, arguments and examples
3. ADVANCED	Objections, replies, comparisons and qualified evaluation
4. EXAM APPLICATION	Verified PYQ routing and marks-wise answer structure
5. RAPID REVISION	Traps, recall spines and mastery preparation

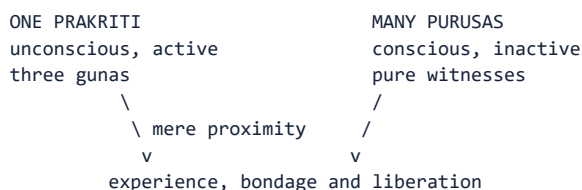
Source audit: the canonical Samkhya knowledge file and complete 2018-2025 Indian Philosophy PYQ bank were checked. The source session's direct OCR anchors to Chatterjee-Datta and C. D. Sharma are retained. A fresh August 2026 search again surfaced an unsupported claim of official adoption of a national "Samkhya Paradigm"; because no official source verifies it, the claim remains excluded. Qdrant was not required.

Preservation note: every substantive section of the earlier complete session is retained. The new material adds simple visual gateways and explicit learning layers without replacing or compressing the original depth.

Progress: 1 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: System Map and Epistemology: How Samkhya Proves the Unseen

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - one world-process and many witnesses



How are they known?
perception + inference + reliable testimony

In simple words: Samkhya says everything objectifiable—including mind and intellect—belongs to Prakriti. Consciousness itself is Purusa. Because neither root Prakriti nor Purusa is ordinarily perceived, the system must infer them.

Pramana	Easy role
Perception	Knows presented objects
Inference	Reaches causes and imperceptible principles
Testimony	Trustworthy verbal knowledge
Samanyato-drsta inference	Decisive route to Prakriti and Purusa

Memory line: three means of knowledge support two ultimate realities.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

0. ONE-SCREEN MAP

SĀMĀKHYA (Sāmkhya) = radical dualism + realist evolutionism + nirīśvara soteriology

ULTIMATE REALITIES

Puruṣa = pure consciousness, many, inactive, witness

Prakṛti = one, unconscious, material root, three guṇas in equilibrium

KEY MOVE

Puruṣa's mere proximity to Prakṛti disturbs guṇa-equilibrium

-> evolution of 23 further tattvas

-> experience, bondage, striving, discrimination

-> kaivalya when Puruṣa knows: "I am not Prakṛti"

DOCTRINAL PILLARS

Prakṛti -> inferred unmanifest root (pradhāna / avyakta)

Puruṣa -> inferred conscious witness distinct from guṇas

Causation -> satkāryavāda + pariṇāmavāda

Liberation -> viveka-jñāna, not divine grace

EXAM HOTSPOTS

2019 -> one Prakṛti? • jīva vs puruṣa

2021 -> three guṇas and guṇa-pariṇāma

2022 -> proofs for Puruṣa

2023 -> Śāṅkara on puruṣa-prakṛti relation

2024 -> full tattva evolution; buddhi/mahat/ahaṁkāra

2025 -> why Śāṅkara treats Sāmkhya as pradhāna-māla

ANALYSIS: Fast memory line: one Prakṛti, many Puruṣas, real evolution, no God, liberation by discrimination.

0A. SĀMĀKHYA EPISTEMOLOGY — PRAMĀṆA AND COGNITION

0A.1 The three-pramāṇa scheme

Statement. FACT: Sāmkhya admits exactly **three pramāṇas** (valid means of knowledge): **dr̥ṣṭa / pratyakṣa** (perception), **anumāna** (inference) and **āptavacana / śabda** (reliable testimony).

Statement. FACT: Other proposed pramāṇas — **upamāna** (comparison), **arthāpatti** (postulation), **anupalabdhi** (non-apprehension), **sambhava** (inclusion/probability) and **aitihya** (traditional report) — are not rejected as useless; they are reduced to, or included within, these three.

Exam use. ANALYSIS: This epistemology is the hinge of the whole system: because **mūla-prakṛti** (root Prakṛti) and **puruṣa** are not sense-objects, Sāmkhya must show how they can still be known without multiplying pramāṇas.

0A.2 Definitions of the three pramāṇas

Statement. FACT: **Dr̥ṣṭa / pratyakṣa** is the **prativīṣayādhyavasāya** (ascertainment with respect to a presented object) of objects through the sense-capacities in contact with them.

Distinction. FACT: **Anumāna** is threefold:

Type of anumāna	Meaning	Example
pūrvavat	FACT: From an antecedent cause/sign to a later effect	FACT: Clouds -> likely rain
śeṣavat	FACT: From an effect/residue back to its cause or wider ground	FACT: Tasting one drop of seawater -> seawater is salty
sāmānyato-dr̥ṣṭa	FACT: From a general correlation where the connection between the terms is not itself directly perceived	FACT: Seeing the sun in different positions -> the sun moves

Statement. FACT: **Āptavacana / śabda** is the word of a trustworthy source, pre-eminently **Veda / śruti**, where the speaker or text is not defective and the object is not otherwise easily known.

0A.3 Reduction of other candidate pramāṇas

Candidate pramāṇa	Sāṃkhya reduction	One-line reason
upamāna	FACT: Included in inference/testimony	FACT: Similarity works because a prior verbal report is applied inferentially to a present case.
arthāpatti	FACT: Included in inference	FACT: Postulation is an inference to the best explanatory condition; it does not need a separate instrument.
anupalabdhi	FACT: Included under perception's failure-conditions, not a separate pramāṇa	FACT: Non-perception means the conditions for perceiving the object are absent or the object is unavailable; no new instrument is required.
sambhava	FACT: Included in inference	FACT: Inclusion from a larger unit to a smaller or probable implication is inferential dependence.
aitihya	FACT: Included in testimony when reliable, otherwise rejected	FACT: Mere tradition has force only when it becomes trustworthy verbal cognition.

0A.4 Why sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa inference is decisive

Statement. FACT: **Avyakta / mūla-prakṛti** and **puruṣa** are both **atīndriya** (beyond the senses): neither is an object of ordinary perception.

Statement. FACT: Their imperceptibility is not proof of non-existence; the standard non-perception discussion assigns mūla-prakṛti's imperceptibility to **saukṣmya** (subtlety), and Puruṣa is likewise atīndriya rather than non-existent.

Distinction. FACT: Sāṃkhya lists standard causes of non-perception: excessive distance, excessive proximity, defect of the organ, inattention of mind, subtlety, obstruction by an intervening object, being overpowered by something else, and admixture with like things.

Argument. ANALYSIS: Since perception cannot reach atīndriya entities, and testimony alone would beg the question against non-Vedic opponents, the argumentative burden falls on **anumāna**, specifically **sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa anumāna**.

Argument. ANALYSIS: Sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa inference can reach a term that is in principle imperceptible because it does not require the vyāpti (invariable relation) to be established by seeing both terms together; it works through a general correlation of kinds.

Conclusion. ANALYSIS: Therefore the five arguments for Prakṛti and the arguments for Puruṣa are not rhetorical flourishes; they discharge an epistemological obligation created by Sāṃkhya's own three-pramāṇa scheme.

Exam use. ANALYSIS: A strong answer should write: **Sāṃkhya first restricts pramāṇas to three, then uses sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa inference to justify the two entities that perception cannot give — Prakṛti and Puruṣa.**

0A.5 Presupposition and objections

Presupposition. ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya presupposes that inference from general correlation can legitimately reach an entity of a kind never itself observed as a sense-object.

Objection. CAUTION: **Cārvāka**: vyāpti cannot be secured for a term never perceived; therefore inference to mūla-prakṛti or puruṣa is speculative.

Reply. ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya answers that strict perceptualism cannot explain ordinary causal reasoning either; manifest, dependent, purposive and objectifiable experience demands an unmanifest material ground and a conscious witness.

Objection. CAUTION: **Nyāya**: sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa inference is legitimate, but Sāṃkhya overuses it; a plurality of atoms plus an intelligent Īśvara explains the ordered world more economically than an unobservable material first cause.

Reply. ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya replies that the continuity between cause and effect, the guṇa-character of experience, and the determinacy of production are better explained by a single material Prakṛti; adding Īśvara is unnecessary

because it does not explain the material continuity itself.

0A.6 Theory of cognition: antahkaraṇa and reflection

Statement. FACT: The **antahkaraṇa** (inner instrument) has three functions: **buddhi** (determinative intellect), **ahaṃkāra** (I-maker) and **manas** (coordinating mind).

Statement. FACT: The full **trayodaśa-karaṇa** (thirteen-fold instrument) consists of 3 internal organs + 5 **buddhīndriyas** / **jñānendriyas** (cognitive sense-capacities) + 5 **karmendriyas** (action-capacities).

Instrument	Function
buddhi	FACT: Final ascertainment (adhyavasāya), judgement, discrimination
ahaṃkāra	FACT: Appropriation as "I" and "mine"
manas	FACT: Coordination, attention, synthesis of sense-data
five buddhīndriyas	FACT: Cognitive access to sound, touch, form, taste and smell
five karmendriyas	FACT: Speech, grasping, movement, excretion and reproduction/action-functions

Distinction. FACT: The external faculties function as **dvāra** (doors), while the inner organ functions as **dvārin** (doorkeeper/door-supervisor) because it receives, coordinates and determines what enters cognition.

Statement. FACT: **Buddhi alone makes the final ascertainment (adhyavasāya)**; manas only coordinates and ahaṃkāra only appropriates.

Argument. FACT: Buddhi is sattva-predominant and therefore transparent; it reflects Puruṣa's consciousness through **puruṣa-cchāyā-āpatti** / **buddhi-pratibimba** (falling of Puruṣa's shadow/reflection in buddhi).

Conclusion. ANALYSIS: Cognition seems conscious although buddhi is **jaḍa** (insentient), because reflected consciousness illuminates buddhi's operations.

Statement. FACT: This reflection generates **abhimāna** (false appropriation: "I am the doer/knower/enjoyer"), and that abhimāna is the psychological root of bondage.

Exam use. ANALYSIS: For Sāṃkhya, the mind does not know by itself and Puruṣa does not act by itself; empirical knowing is a reflected-consciousness event in buddhi.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced proof burden and cognition model

Samkhya reduces comparison, postulation, non-apprehension and tradition to its three accepted pramanas. This economy creates a burden: imperceptible Prakṛiti and Puruṣa cannot simply be asserted. *Samanyato-drṣṭa* inference must reach entities never presented as ordinary sense-objects.

Carvaka attacks the unobserved universal relation, while Nyaya grants inference but proposes atoms and Isvara as a more economical explanation. Samkhya replies that material continuity, guna-patterns and the objectifiability of experience jointly require one material root and a distinct witness.

Empirical cognition occurs through the inner instrument. Manas coordinates, ahaṃkāra appropriates and buddhi determines. Buddhi remains insentient but appears conscious through Puruṣa's reflection, producing the false appropriation that grounds bondage.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- Begin broad answers with: **one Prakriti, many Purusas, three gunas, twenty-five tattvas, liberation by discrimination.**
- For metaphysical proofs, first explain why perception cannot establish the two ultimate principles.
- Distinguish buddhi's determination, ahamkara's appropriation and manas's coordination.
- Evaluate whether inference from objectifiable experience genuinely establishes a wholly non-objective witness.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Three pramanas: perception, inference and testimony.
- Samanyato-drsta inference reaches imperceptible principles.
- Inner organ: buddhi + ahamkara + manas.
- Buddhi is material and insentient despite reflected consciousness.
- Trap: Purusa does not perform cognition as a changing mental act.

Progress: 2 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Prakriti and the Three Gunas: One Material Root of Diversity

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - equilibrium becomes evolution

SATTVA = illumination
RAJAS = activity
TAMAS = inertia

balanced proportions -> unmanifest Prakriti
disturbed proportions -> differentiated world

In simple words: Prakriti is not merely physical matter. It is the common source of body, senses, mind, ego and intellect. Its three inseparable tendencies explain clarity, motion and resistance across both psychology and cosmology.

Name	Emphasis
Prakriti	Productive material nature
Pradhana	Chief material principle
Avyakta	Unmanifest state
Samyavastha	Equilibrium of the gunas

Memory line: one unmanifest guna-equilibrium unfolds into all objective diversity.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

1. PRAKṚTI (prakṛiti) — the primal material principle

1.1 Statement

- FACT: **Prakṛti (prakṛiti)** is the unmanifest, unconscious, primordial material principle from which the entire objective and psycho-physical world evolves.
- FACT: It is also called **pradhāna** (chief principle) because it is the primary material basis of all empirical manifestation.
- FACT: It is called **avyakta** (unmanifest) because in its primordial condition it is not yet differentiated into manifest tattvas.
- FACT: It is not a created entity; it is the ultimate **material cause** of the world within Sāṃkhya's dualist ontology.
- ANALYSIS: In exam language, Prakṛti is not merely "matter" in the modern physicalist sense; it includes the roots of intellect, ego, mind, senses, subtle elements and gross elements.

1.2 Why Sāṃkhya needs Prakṛti

- FACT: The world is marked by plurality, transformation, dependence, teleology and structured manifestation.
- FACT: A school that accepts real effects, real bondage and real liberation needs a real material source from which empirical diversity emerges.
- FACT: Since Puruṣa is changeless and inactive, it cannot itself become the world.
- FACT: Therefore a second principle is required: active but unconscious Prakṛti.

1.3 The five arguments for the existence of Prakṛti

- FACT: Sāṃkhya argues for Prakṛti by inference. The standard cluster of arguments is central to UPSC.

(1) **bhedānām parimāṇāt — from the finitude and determinateness of things**

- FACT: Empirical things are many, finite, delimited and measurable.
- FACT: What is finite and determinate points beyond itself to a more fundamental source from which such determinate forms arise.
- FACT: The manifold world therefore requires a common antecedent material ground.
- ANALYSIS: The force of the argument is not merely "every effect has a cause," but "the limited and differentiated presuppose a subtler ground from which limitation and differentiation emerge."

(2) **samanvayāt — from the uniformity / homogeneity running through effects**

- FACT: Effects display an underlying order and common pattern.
- FACT: Diverse products nevertheless reveal continuity of constitution and dependence.
- FACT: Such systematic coherence suggests a common material basis.
- ANALYSIS: This is an argument from coordinated diversity: if effects hang together, they are likely rooted in one underlying matrix.

(3) **kāryataḥ pravṛtteḥ — from purposive activity directed toward effects**

- FACT: The empirical order is not inert chaos; it is a field of production, activity and transformation.
- FACT: Productive activity presupposes a causal potency capable of issuing in determinate effects.
- FACT: Therefore there must be an underlying productive principle possessing the capacity for manifestation.
- ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya here reasons from the fact of becoming to an abiding source of becoming.

(4) **kāraṇa-kārya-vibhāgāt — from the distinction between cause and effect**

- FACT: Cause and effect are distinguishable stages: the unmanifest source and the manifest product are not identical in appearance.
- FACT: If effects are manifest, multiple and differentiated, their cause must be a more basic, prior and subtler condition.
- FACT: Thus the manifest order implies an unmanifest causal matrix distinct from it as cause from effect.
- ANALYSIS: The point is not total disconnection: cause and effect are distinguishable without being unrelated.

(5) avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya — from the undivided source of the diversified universe

- FACT: The world is astonishingly diverse, yet this diversity forms one interconnected cosmos.
- FACT: A diversified whole points back to an undivided source in which later differentiations are not yet separated.
- FACT: Therefore there must be an original unmanifest, undivided root of the whole world-process.
- FACT: **This is the proof that shows Prakṛti must be ONE.**
- FACT: UPSC 2019 directly tests this point: if the diversity of the world issues from an **undivided** source, that source cannot itself be many disconnected material ultimates; it must be singular.
- ANALYSIS: This is the strongest anti-pluralist argument at the level of material causation in Sāṃkhya.

1.4 Which proof establishes that there can be only one Prakṛti?

- FACT: The proof is **avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya**.
- FACT: Reason: if the entire articulated universe emerges from an undivided source, that source must itself be singular, not many independent primal materials.
- ANALYSIS: In a 10-marker, do not merely name the proof. Add the logical bridge: plurality at the root would undermine the inference to an undivided source of total cosmic diversity.

1.5 The three guṇas (gunas)

Guṇa	Core character	Affective tone	Main function in evolution
sattva	lightness, illumination, buoyancy	pleasure	revelation, clarity, manifestation, knowledge
rajas	activity, restlessness, propulsion	pain	energy, stimulation, movement, mediation
tamas	heaviness, obstruction, inertia	delusion	concealment, resistance, fixation, material density

- FACT: **Sattva** is luminous, clear and upward-moving; it makes cognition and manifestation possible.
- FACT: **Rajas** is dynamic, agitating and projective; it supplies motion, effort and transition.
- FACT: **Tamas** is heavy, obscuring and resistant; it produces inertia, concealment and confusion.
- FACT: Pleasure is associated with sattva, pain with rajas, delusion with tamas.
- ANALYSIS: The guṇas are not three separable substances but three inseparable constitutive tendencies within one Prakṛti.

1.6 Equilibrium and disturbance

- FACT: Before manifestation, the three guṇas exist in equilibrium called **sāmyāvasthā**.
- FACT: In this state Prakṛti is **avyakta**, unmanifest.
- FACT: Manifest evolution begins when this equilibrium is disturbed in the presence of Puruṣa.
- ANALYSIS: Disturbance should not be imagined as mechanical collision; Sāṃkhya speaks of functional activation in proximity.

1.7 Guṇa-pariṇāma

sarūpa-pariṇāma — homogeneous transformation

- FACT: In equilibrium, each guṇa transforms within its own nature.
- FACT: This is **sarūpa-pariṇāma**, same-form transformation.
- ANALYSIS: It preserves the idea that Prakṛti is dynamic even in the unmanifest state without yet producing differentiated effects.

virūpa-pariṇāma — heterogeneous transformation

- FACT: When equilibrium is disturbed, the guṇas enter asymmetrical relations and produce differentiated evolutes.
- FACT: This is **virūpa-pariṇāma**, heterogeneous transformation.
- FACT: Actual cosmological evolution belongs to virūpa-pariṇāma.
- FACT: UPSC 2021 on the guṇas and their modifications directly maps here.

1.8 Prakṛti as pradhāna and avyakta

- FACT: **Pradhāna** emphasizes that Prakṛti is the chief material principle.
- FACT: **Avyakta** emphasizes that it is unmanifest prior to differentiated evolution.
- ANALYSIS: An exam-safe definition: **Prakṛti is the avyakta pradhāna, the unmanifest chief material principle constituted by the three guṇas.**

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced arguments and internal tension

The five arguments infer Prakṛti from finite effects, common constitution, productive activity, cause-effect distinction and unified diversity. *Avibhagat vaisvarupyasya* most directly supports one Prakṛti: a diversified cosmos is traced to one undivided source.

Guna theory gains explanatory unity by covering physical, cognitive and affective phenomena with the same three factors. Its weakness is elasticity: nearly any phenomenon can be redescribed as a proportion of sattva, rajas and tamas, making independent testing difficult.

The system also distinguishes homogeneous guna-change in equilibrium from heterogeneous transformation in manifestation. This keeps Prakṛti dynamic even before gross evolution while preserving a real transition to the manifest order.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- **2019 Q8(c):** identify *avibhagat vaisvarupyasya*, then supply the logical bridge from unified diversity to one root.
- **2021 Q6(b):** define all three gunas, show their mutual dependence and distinguish homogeneous from heterogeneous modification.
- Do not call the gunas optional qualities; they are Prakṛti's constitutive factors.
- Add the teleology problem: how can an unconscious root evolve for another's sake?

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Prakṛti: one, eternal, unconscious, unmanifest material cause.
- Sattva illuminates; rajas activates; tamas restrains.
- Equilibrium = avyakta; disequilibrium = manifest evolution.
- Avibhagat vaisvarupyasya supports one Prakṛti.
- Trap: Prakṛti includes mind and intellect, not only gross matter.

Progress: 3 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Purusa: Pure Consciousness, Plurality and the Empirical Jiva

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - witness is not the mental screen

BODY -> SENSES -> MANAS -> AHAMKARA -> BUDDHI
all are observable Prakṛti
|
v
reflected consciousness
|
PURUSA witnesses

In simple words: even the mind is an object in Samkhya. Purusa is the unchanging consciousness to which bodily and mental states appear. The empirical jiva is Purusa seemingly tied to intellect, ego and the subtle body.

Purusa	Prakriti's evolutes
Conscious	Unconscious
Inactive	Active
Changeless	Transforming
Witness	Seen and used

Memory line: the knower of every change cannot be one more changing object.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

2. PURUṢA (purusha) — the conscious principle

2.1 Statement

- FACT: **Puruṣa (purusha)** is pure consciousness, self-luminous, inactive, changeless and beyond the guṇas.
- FACT: Consciousness is not a quality in Puruṣa; it is Puruṣa's very essence.
- FACT: Puruṣa is witness, seer and experiencer, but not agent in the productive sense.

2.2 The five arguments for the existence of Puruṣa

Statement. FACT: Sāṃkhya argues for Puruṣa as a distinct conscious principle because the entire objective complex is unconscious, instrumental and presented to experience.

(1) saṅghāta-parārthatvāt — aggregates exist for another

Statement. FACT: Body, senses, mind and buddhi are **saṅghāta** (aggregates/complexes).

Argument. FACT: Aggregates function instrumentally; an instrument is for a user or beneficiary distinct from it.

Conclusion. FACT: Hence there must be a conscious Puruṣa for whose experience and release the aggregate functions.

(2) triguṇādi-viparyayāt — the witness must be other than the guṇas

Statement. FACT: The guṇas are objective, mutable and characterized by pleasure, pain and delusion.

Argument. FACT: The knower of pleasure, pain and delusion cannot be reducible to the same changing guṇic states that are known.

Conclusion. FACT: Therefore a non-guṇic conscious principle must be admitted.

(3) adhiṣṭhānāt — organized experience requires a presiding locus

Statement. FACT: Psychophysical life displays coordinated functioning rather than disconnected flashes.

Argument. ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya infers a conscious support in whose presence the unconscious system becomes an experienced order.

Conclusion. FACT: This is not a God-proof; it is an inference to Puruṣa as the presiding witness of lived order.

(4) bhokṭṛ-bhāvāt — experience requires an enjoyer

Statement. FACT: Pleasure, pain and delusion are experienced.

Argument. FACT: Since these are presented as objects or states, there must be a **bhokṭṛ** (experiencer/enjoyer) distinct from them.

Conclusion. FACT: Unconscious Prakṛti can present experience, but it cannot be the subject for whom experience appears.

(5) kaivalyārthaṃ pravṛtṭeḥ — striving for liberation presupposes a liberable witness

Statement. FACT: Human striving for release from suffering is a central fact for Sāṃkhya.

Argument. FACT: Such striving would be unintelligible if there were no conscious principle distinct from bondage-producing Prakṛti.

Conclusion. FACT: The orientation toward **kaivalya** presupposes Puruṣa.

2.3 Evaluation of the five proofs

- ANALYSIS: The proofs are cumulative, not isolated.
- ANALYSIS: Together they argue that aggregates are instrumental, guṇas are objectifiable, experience requires a witness, and liberation presupposes a self.
- ANALYSIS: Their epistemic form is **sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa anumāna**: from the general structure of objectifiable experience to a witness that is never itself an object.
- FACT: UPSC 2022 asked these proofs directly; list, explain and then briefly assess their cumulative force.

2.4 Plurality of Puruṣas

Statement. FACT: Sāṃkhya holds that Puruṣas are many, not one.

Distinction. ANALYSIS: Plurality does not mean qualitative difference among Puruṣas; each Puruṣa is pure, inactive consciousness, but they are numerically many.

2.4.1 Standard arguments for plurality

Argument. FACT: **From diversity of birth, death and sense-faculties**: if there were only one Puruṣa, the birth or death of one body would be the birth or death of all, and all would be blind when one is blind.

Argument. FACT: **From non-simultaneity of activity**: beings act at different times and in different ways; if there were one self, all embodied streams would act together.

Argument. FACT: **From differential distribution of the three guṇas**: beings differ as sattvic, rajasic or tamasic in temperament; this supports distinct centres of experience rather than one undifferentiated experiencer.

Argument. FACT: **From liberation of some and not others**: if the self were one, liberation of one would imply liberation of all; since some remain bound while another may be released, Puruṣas must be many.

Exam use. ANALYSIS: Present these as the standard arguments for plurality; do not tie them to an exact canonical count unless the question specifically demands textual enumeration.

2.4.2 Presuppositions behind the plurality argument

Presupposition	Why it matters
Empirical individuation transfers upward	ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya assumes differences in bodies and mental streams license an inference to distinct Puruṣas.
Puruṣa is genuinely bhoktṛ	ANALYSIS: If experience has no owner, the question "whose pleasure or pain?" loses force.
Liberation is particular	ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya treats liberation as attributable to a particular Puruṣa's psychophysical stream, not merely as the collapse of a universal illusion.
Numerical plurality of attributeless consciousness is intelligible	ANALYSIS: The school accepts numerical difference without qualitative difference.

2.4.3 Objections and replies

Objection. CAUTION: **Advaita / Śaṅkara**: every difference cited is a difference in **upādhis** (limiting adjuncts — bodies, minds, guṇa-configurations), not in consciousness itself. Pure consciousness, being without attribute, part, action or spatial location, admits no principle of individuation; therefore Sāṃkhya proves at most a plurality of **cittas** (mental streams), not Puruṣas.

Reply. FACT: Sāṃkhya replies that if there were one Puruṣa, the bondage of one would be the bondage of all and the release of one the release of all; the reflection model also requires distinct reflected loci in distinct buddhis.

Residual force. ANALYSIS: Advaita answers that bondage itself is adventitious and the many jīvas are apparent, so the exchange terminates in a clash of first principles: Sāṃkhya trusts the plurality given in experience, while Advaita

subordinates plurality to the unity given in śruti.

Objection. CAUTION: **Nyāya:** Nyāya agrees that selves are many, but objects to a purely inactive self; an agent-less self cannot be the locus of moral desert, so Nyāya makes ātman a substance with adventitious cognition, volition and effort.

Reply. FACT: Sāṃkhya replies that agency belongs to Prakṛti's evolutes; ascribing agency to Puruṣa is precisely the **abhimāna** that bondage consists in.

Objection. CAUTION: **Buddhist:** a permanent, changeless and actionless entity is causally idle and therefore, by **arthakriyā** (efficacy), unreal.

Reply. FACT: Sāṃkhya replies that Puruṣa's efficacy is not productive causation but **sannidhi / sānnidhya** (mere presence) that renders Prakṛti's activity experienced; without Puruṣa the teleology of Prakṛti (**puruṣārtha**) is unintelligible.

Objection. CAUTION: **Internal objection:** if Puruṣas are all identical in nature — pure, attributeless consciousness — what makes them numerically many?

Reply. ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya's honest answer is that plurality is inferred from the non-transferability of experience, bondage and liberation, but the ultimate individuation of qualitatively identical Puruṣas remains the school's weakest joint.

2.4.4 Teleology of Prakṛti for Puruṣa

Statement. FACT: Prakṛti acts for **puruṣārtha** — the sake of Puruṣa — by providing experience and finally the possibility of discriminative release.

Example. FACT: Prakṛti is said to function **like milk flowing for the calf**: unconscious, yet serving a purposive end.

Example. FACT: Puruṣa and Prakṛti cooperate **like the lame man and the blind man**: Puruṣa can see but not act; Prakṛti can act but not see.

Example. FACT: Prakṛti is **like a dancer who retires once she has been seen**: after discriminative knowledge, she no longer performs binding activity for that Puruṣa.

Example. FACT: Prakṛti is also **like a modest woman who withdraws on being seen**: once her distinction from Puruṣa is disclosed, concealment ends.

Objection. CAUTION: Unconscious teleology appears incoherent because purposiveness seems to require intelligence.

Reply. ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya replies that purposive functioning need not be conscious planning; the guṇa-structure naturally unfolds in the presence of Puruṣa, just as milk nourishes the calf without deliberation.

2.5 Nature of Puruṣa

Feature	Sāṃkhya position
Consciousness	essence, not quality
Activity	inactive, non-productive
Change	changeless, immutable
Relation to guṇas	entirely beyond them
Status	witness, seer, experiencer

- FACT: Puruṣa does not become bound in its own nature; bondage belongs to misidentification.
- FACT: Puruṣa does not produce the world; all production belongs to Prakṛti.

2.6 Jīva vs Puruṣa

- FACT: **Puruṣa** is the metaphysical reality: pure, inactive, changeless consciousness.
- FACT: **Jīva** is not a separate tattva.
- FACT: Jīva is Puruṣa as empirically appearing through identification with buddhi, ahaṁkāra, mind, body and karmic stream.
- FACT: Thus jīva is the conditioned empirical self, while Puruṣa is the unconditioned conscious reality behind it.
- FACT: UPSC 2019 directly asked the metaphysical status of jīva and puruṣa.
- ANALYSIS: Best formulation: **jīva is Puruṣa as empirically conditioned through buddhi; Puruṣa is the metaphysical reality behind that appearance.**

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced proofs and individuation problem

The five proofs argue cumulatively from instrumental aggregates, opposition to the gunas, coordinated experience, enjoyment and striving for liberation. Their strongest shared insight is the irreducibility of subjectivity to what is objectified.

Samkhya nevertheless posits many qualitatively identical Purusas to explain separate births, capacities, actions, karmic streams and non-simultaneous liberation. Critics ask what individuates attributeless witnesses. Appeals to distinct subtle bodies explain empirical streams but risk shifting plurality away from Purusa itself.

The jiva-Purusa distinction protects purity: agency and bondage belong to reflected consciousness in buddhi and ahamkara, not to Purusa as such. The cost is an obscure moral subject—what truly acts if the conscious pole is inactive and the active pole unconscious?

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- **2018 Q5(e)**: argue plurality through separate births, faculties, activity, karma and liberation; then raise individuation.
- **2019 Q5(d)**: distinguish pure Purusa from empirically conditioned jiva.
- **2022 Q5(a)**: list and evaluate all five proofs as a cumulative case.
- Never state that Purusa creates, changes, desires or acts.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Purusa is pure, self-luminous, inactive and beyond the gunas.
- Five proofs: aggregate, contrast, presiding witness, experiencer, liberation-striving.
- Purusas are numerically many but qualitatively alike.
- Jiva is not a new tattva.
- Trap: consciousness is Purusa's essence, unlike Nyaya where it is a quality.

Progress: 4 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Twenty-Five Tattvas and Satkaryavada: Evolution as Real Transformation

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - from unmanifest root to experienced world

PRAKRITI
|
MAHAT / BUDDHI
|
AHAMKARA
+-- sattvika -> manas + 10 faculties
+-- tamasa -> 5 subtle elements -> 5 gross elements
+-- rajas -> energizes both lines

PURUSA = 25th tattva, never an evolute

In simple words: Samkhya's evolution joins cosmology and psychology. The same material principle produces the external world and the instruments through which it is experienced.

MANGO SEED -> MANGO TREE
specific cause -> specific real transformation
the effect exists latently, not as a tiny visible tree

Memory line: the world unfolds from what the cause is capable of becoming.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

3. THE 25 TATTVAS — FULL EVOLUTIONARY SEQUENCE

3.1 Full sequence

Prakṛti
↓
mahat / buddhi
↓
ahaṁkāra
+- sāttvika line -> manas + 5 jñānendriyas + 5 karmendriyas
+- tāmasa line -> 5 tanmātras -> 5 mahābhūtas
+- rājasa factor -> supplies energy to both lines

Puruṣa = 25th tattva, but not an evolute of Prakṛti

3.2 Ordered list

No.	Tattva	Note
1	Prakṛti	root material cause
2	mahat / buddhi	first evolute
3	ahaṁkāra	principle of individuation
4	manas	internal coordinator
5-9	five jñānendriyas	cognitive senses
10-14	five karmendriyas	action faculties
15-19	five tanmātras	subtle elements
20-24	five mahābhūtas	gross elements
25	Puruṣa	pure consciousness, non-evolute

3.3 Mahat, buddhi and ahaṁkāra

- FACT: **Mahat and buddhi are the SAME tattva.**
- FACT: **Mahat** is the cosmic aspect or name.
- FACT: **Buddhi** is the individual/psychological aspect or name.
- FACT: **Ahaṁkāra** emerges **from** buddhi/mahat as the principle of individuation or I-sense.
- FACT: Therefore the sequence is **Prakṛti -> mahat/buddhi -> ahaṁkāra.**
- ANALYSIS: This is a classic UPSC trap. Never write mahat and buddhi as two separate stages.

3.4 Buddhi

- FACT: Buddhi determines, judges, ascertains and discriminates.
- FACT: It is the locus where reflected consciousness is most conspicuous in empirical life.
- ANALYSIS: In psychology: manas coordinates, ahaṁkāra appropriates, buddhi determines.

3.5 Ahaṁkāra

- FACT: Ahaṁkāra is the I-maker, the principle of individuation.
- FACT: It appropriates functions into the form "I know," "I act," "I experience."
- ANALYSIS: It is central to bondage because false selfhood crystallizes here.

3.6 Sāttvika line

- FACT: From the sāttvika aspect of ahaṁkāra arise **manas, five jñānendriyas, and five karmendriyas.**
- FACT: This line accounts for the cognitive and conative equipment of empirical life.

3.7 Tāmasa line

- FACT: From the tāmasa aspect of ahaṁkāra arise the **five tanmātras.**
- FACT: From the five tanmātras arise the **five mahābhūtas.**
- FACT: This line accounts for subtle-to-gross material manifestation.

3.8 Rājasa factor

- FACT: Rajas supplies activity, energy and operative force to both lines.
- FACT: **Rājasa ahaṁkāra does not produce a separate set of tattvas.**
- ANALYSIS: This must be written explicitly because it is repeatedly confused.

3.9 Why this sequence matters philosophically

- FACT: The sequence shows that cosmology and psychology are internally linked in Sāṁkhya.
- FACT: The same Prakṛti that yields matter also yields the faculties through which matter is experienced.
- ANALYSIS: UPSC 2024 as a 20-marker is exactly about narrating this structure cleanly and then explaining the buddhi/mahat/ahaṁkāra distinction.

4. CAUSATION — SATKĀRYAVĀDA

4.1 Statement

- FACT: **Satkāryavāda** holds that the effect pre-exists in its material cause.
- FACT: Production is manifestation, not creation out of sheer non-being.
- FACT: Sāṁkhya's specific form of satkāryavāda is **pariṇāmavāda**, the doctrine of real transformation.

4.2 The five arguments for satkāryavāda

Statement. FACT: The standard Sāṃkhya set gives five reasons for holding that the effect pre-exists in its material cause.

(1) asadakaraṇāt — because what does not exist cannot be brought into being

Statement. FACT: A sheer non-entity cannot be produced.

Argument. FACT: No amount of causal operation can produce a hare's horn or oil from sand; production presupposes something determinate to be produced.

Example. FACT: A potter's effort can manifest a pot from clay, but it cannot manifest a square circle from nothing.

Objection. CAUTION: **Nyāya:** Sāṃkhya equivocates between the absolutely non-existent and the merely not-yet-existent; Nyāya denies only that the pot exists as a pot before production.

Reply. ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya presses that the "not-yet-existent" effect must still be something in the material cause, otherwise the operation would have no determinate terminus.

(2) upādāna-grahaṇāt — because a determinate material cause is taken up

Statement. FACT: Specific effects require specific material causes.

Argument. FACT: One who wants curd takes milk, not water; one who wants cloth takes threads, not clay.

Example. FACT: The selection of mango seed rather than sand for a mango tree shows a determinate causal base.

Objection. CAUTION: The restriction may be explained by causal capacity rather than by the pre-existence of the effect.

Reply. ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya replies that causal capacity in the required determinate sense just is the latent presence of that effect in that material continuum.

(3) sarvasambhavābhāvāt — because everything cannot arise from everything

Statement. FACT: If effects were wholly non-existent before production, any cause could produce any effect.

Argument. FACT: Non-existence as such is indistinguishable; therefore it cannot explain why curd arises from milk and not from water.

Example. FACT: Cloth comes from threads, not from milk; curd comes from milk, not from threads.

Objection. CAUTION: A rival can say that restrictions come from the constitution of causes, not from effects already existing in causes.

Reply. ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya replies that a constitution capable of producing only X is precisely the latent presence of X as a determinate effect-potential.

(4) śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt — because the efficient can produce only what it is capable of producing

Statement. FACT: A cause has a determinate śakti (potency) directed toward a determinate effect.

Argument. FACT: A potency for X is unintelligible unless X is in some manner already there as the object of that potency.

Example. FACT: Milk has the potency for curd, not for cloth; threads have the potency for cloth, not for curd.

Objection. CAUTION: **Nyāya:** potency is a relational property of the cause, not the effect in latent form.

Reply. ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya replies that a merely relational potency cannot explain determinate production unless the producible form is already grounded in the material cause.

(5) kāraṇa-bhāvāt — because the effect has the nature/being of the cause

Statement. FACT: The effect is non-different from the cause in substance.

Argument. FACT: Cloth is nothing over and above threads in a certain arrangement; it has the same material basis, weight and guṇa-continuity.

Example. FACT: Ornament and gold differ in form and name, but the material substance remains gold.

Objection. CAUTION: **Nyāya:** the whole (avayavin) is a new substance with new properties; a cloth covers, but separate threads do not.

Reply. ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya replies that the new properties are new **saṃsthāna** (arrangements/configurations), not new substances created out of non-being.

4.3 Why Sāṃkhya's satkāryavāda is pariṇāmavāda

Statement. FACT: Sāṃkhya's satkāryavāda is specifically **pariṇāmavāda**: the effect is a real transformation of the cause.

Distinction. FACT: It is not **vivartavāda**, because the world is not a mere appearance superimposed on an unchanged cause; it is the real evolution of Prakṛti.

Argument. FACT: The mechanism is **guṇa-pariṇāma**: the three guṇas transform and recombine to produce the differentiated tattvas.

Distinction. FACT: In **sarūpa-pariṇāma**, each guṇa transforms homogeneously within its own nature during **pralaya** or equilibrium; in **virūpa-pariṇāma**, the guṇas transform heterogeneously and generate the manifest evolutes.

Objection. CAUTION: If the effect already exists, causal effort becomes pointless.

Reply. FACT: Production is **abhivyakti** (manifestation) of what is latent; effort removes obstruction and supplies conditions, it does not create being out of non-being.

Objection. CAUTION: Satkāryavāda abolishes the distinction between cause and effect.

Reply. FACT: Cause and effect differ by **avasthā** (state): the cause is latent/unmanifest, the effect is patent/manifest.

Objection. CAUTION: Satkāryavāda implies the world was always exactly as it is now.

Reply. FACT: Sāṃkhya denies that the gross effect is already manifest; only the determinate capacity/effect-form exists latently in the cause.

Exam use. ANALYSIS: The mango-seed example should be written as latent effect + material continuity + real transformation, not as a miniature gross mango tree hidden inside the seed.

4.4 Contrast with Advaita vivartavāda

Issue	Sāṃkhya	Advaita Vedānta
Type of transformation	real	apparent
Technical term	pariṇāma	vivarta
Cause	Prakṛti	Brahman
Status of world	real evolute	ultimately appearance

- FACT: Both may be placed under a broad satkārya orientation, but their accounts of transformation differ radically.

4.5 Contrast with Nyāya asatkāryavāda

Issue	Sāṃkhya	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika
Effect before production	pre-existent in cause	absent as effect (prāgabhāva)
Production	manifestation	new beginning
Causal model	continuity through transformation	effect as fresh product

- FACT: This contrast is directly relevant to the 2023 cross-link question on Nyāya prāgabhāva and Sāṃkhya causation.

4.6 Contrast with Buddhist pratītyasamutpāda

- FACT: Buddhism explains becoming through dependent origination rather than an enduring unmanifest material root.
- FACT: Sāṃkhya explains becoming through transformation of enduring Prakṛti.
- ANALYSIS: A crisp contrast line is often enough unless the question explicitly asks for Buddhist comparison.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced causal argument

The five arguments for satkaryavada deny production from sheer non-being, stress selection of a determinate material cause, reject arbitrary effects, ground determinate causal power and affirm material continuity. Samkhya's version is *parinamavada*: the cause genuinely transforms.

Nyaya can explain specificity through causal powers without saying that the effect already exists. Samkhya replies that a potency directed only toward X is the latent grounding of X in the cause. The debate therefore turns on whether capacity entails pre-existence or only production-ability.

Advaita accepts a broad satkarya orientation but denies real transformation of ultimate reality. Buddhism explains conditioned arising without an enduring Prakriti. These comparisons should sharpen, not replace, Samkhya's own causal derivation.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- **2020 Q7(a)**: use the mango seed to explain latent effect, material continuity, specific potency and real transformation.
- **2024 Q7(a)**: narrate the sequence exactly; mahat and buddhi are the same tattva, while ahamkara follows them.
- State explicitly that rajas energizes both lines and produces no separate tattva-set.
- Compare parinama with Nyaya arambha and Advaita vivarta only after completing the Samkhya case.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Twenty-four Prakriti-side tattvas plus Purusa.
- Mahat = buddhi; ahamkara is the next stage.
- Satkaryavada: effect pre-exists latently.
- Parinamavada: material cause really transforms.
- Trap: no miniature gross tree is hidden in the seed.

Progress: 5 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Kaivalya, the Contact Problem and Sankara's Pradhana-Malla Critique

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - bondage is mistaken identity

BUDDHI acts and reflects consciousness

|
AHAMKARA says "I know, I act, I suffer"

|
PURUSA appears bound

VIVEKA-JNANA:

"All change belongs to Prakriti; I am the witness."

|
KAIVALYA

In simple words: Purusa is never really transformed or tied. Bondage is non-discrimination; liberation is the stable recognition that the witness is distinct from every material and mental process.

Analogy	Purpose
Lame and blind	Complementarity of consciousness and activity
Magnet and iron	Activation through proximity
Crystal and flower	Apparent colouring without real change
Dancer and spectator	Prakriti ceases display after being understood

Memory line: liberation separates by knowledge; it does not merge or destroy.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

5. LIBERATION (KAIVALYA)

5.1 Bondage as aviveka

- FACT: Bondage in Sāṃkhya is **aviveka**, non-discrimination between Puruṣa and Prakṛti.
- FACT: Buddhi reflects consciousness, and this reflection creates false identification.
- FACT: The self then appears as agent, enjoyer, sufferer and knower in the empirical sense.
- ANALYSIS: Bondage is not real alteration in Puruṣa but mistaken identification through reflected consciousness.

5.2 Liberation as viveka-jñāna

- FACT: Liberation is **viveka-jñāna**, discriminative knowledge that "I am not Prakṛti."
- FACT: When the distinction between witness-consciousness and guṇic evolutes becomes steady, false identification ends.
- FACT: This state is **kaivalya**, the aloneness or isolation of Puruṣa.
- ANALYSIS: Kaivalya is not merger; it is disentanglement.

5.3 Lame-and-blind analogy

- FACT: Puruṣa is like the lame: conscious but inactive.
- FACT: Prakṛti is like the blind: active but unconscious.
- FACT: Together they explain empirical process.
- ANALYSIS: The analogy conveys complementarity without collapsing the two principles into one.

5.4 Dancer analogy

- FACT: Prakṛti is like a dancer who stops after being seen by Puruṣa.
- FACT: Once discriminative knowledge arises, Prakṛti no longer continues its binding display for that Puruṣa.
- ANALYSIS: This is the neatest canonical image for liberation through fulfilled disclosure.

5.5 Jīvanmukti and videhamukti

- FACT: **Jīvanmukti** refers to liberation while the body still continues due to prior momentum.
- FACT: The standard analogy is the **potter's wheel** that keeps turning even after the impulse ceases.
- FACT: **Videhamukti** is the final cessation of embodiment when the body falls and residual momentum ends.
- ANALYSIS: In Sāṃkhya this remains isolation of consciousness, not union with God.

5.6 Nirīśvara character of liberation

- FACT: No God is required for either bondage or liberation in classical Sāṃkhya.
- FACT: Prakṛti's teleological evolution for Puruṣa's experience and release is treated as sufficient.
- ANALYSIS: This is why classical Sāṃkhya must be clearly separated from theistic Yoga.

6. PURUṢA–PRAKṚTI CONTACT PROBLEM

6.1 The problem

- FACT: If Puruṣa is inactive and Prakṛti is unconscious, how can they relate at all?
- FACT: Yet the entire system depends on some relation between them to explain evolution, bondage and liberation.
- FACT: This is the famous contact problem, asked in 2023.

6.2 Sāṃkhya response: proximity, not physical contact

- FACT: Sāṃkhya answers that the relation is **sānnidhya**, mere proximity or presence, not gross physical contact.
- FACT: Puruṣa does not push or alter Prakṛti by action.
- FACT: Prakṛti becomes active in the mere presence of Puruṣa.

6.3 Analogies

- FACT: **Magnet and iron**: as a magnet moves iron without deliberative willing, Puruṣa's presence occasions Prakṛti's activity.
- FACT: **Crystal and flower**: as a clear crystal appears coloured by a nearby flower without itself changing, Puruṣa appears affected by Prakṛti without real transformation.
- ANALYSIS: The first analogy explains activation by presence; the second explains apparent contamination without real change.

6.4 Śaṃkara's attack

- FACT: Śaṃkara argues that if Puruṣa is truly inactive and Prakṛti truly unconscious, no intelligible real relation is possible.
- FACT: The magnet analogy fails because even a magnet exerts force; if Puruṣa were like that, it would not be wholly inactive.
- FACT: The crystal analogy may explain appearance, but not the initiation of world-process.
- FACT: Therefore Sāṃkhya dualism appears unstable: either it collapses toward monism or it requires a third mediating principle.
- FACT: UPSC 2023 directly tests this critique of Sāṃkhya dualism.

7. WHY ŚAṂKARA TREATS SĀṂKHYA AS PRADHĀNA MALLA

7.1 Closest systematic rival

- FACT: Sāṁkhya is the most sophisticated non-Vedāntic rival to Advaita at the level of ultimate explanation.
- FACT: It explains world, self, bondage, liberation and causation through a coherent metaphysical system.
- ANALYSIS: It is therefore not marginal but philosophically near enough to require detailed refutation.

7.2 Pariṇāmavāda versus vivartavāda

- FACT: Sāṁkhya's **pariṇāmavāda** is the nearest rival to Advaita's **vivartavāda**.
- FACT: Both aim to explain the world from an ultimate principle, but Sāṁkhya takes transformation as real while Advaita takes it as apparent.
- ANALYSIS: This causal proximity is one reason Śaṁkara treats Sāṁkhya as chief opponent.

7.3 Shared appeal to a single ultimate explanatory ground

- FACT: Sāṁkhya explains the world through one primal material principle, Prakṛti/pradhāna.
- FACT: Advaita too seeks a single ultimate explanatory ground, though in the form of conscious Brahman rather than unconscious matter.
- ANALYSIS: Because both are large-scale metaphysical explanations, the contest is direct.

7.4 Śaṁkara's objections

- FACT: **Unconscious prakṛti cannot be the Upaniṣadic cause** because the Upaniṣadic source is described as conscious, knowing and sat-cit in character.
- FACT: **The contact problem remains unresolved:** inactive Puruṣa and unconscious Prakṛti cannot intelligibly relate.
- FACT: **Teleology cannot be explained without consciousness:** if Prakṛti evolves "for the sake of" Puruṣa, purposiveness seems to require intelligence.
- FACT: **Texts describing the cause as knowing (tajjñāḥ-type descriptions) exclude jaḍa-prakṛti.**
- FACT: UPSC 2025 makes this a 20-marker shared with Vedanta.md.

7.5 Exam conclusion

- ANALYSIS: Śaṁkara calls Sāṁkhya his chief opponent because it is the strongest rival causal-metaphysical system; he rejects it because the ultimate cause must be conscious, teleology cannot rest on unconscious Prakṛti, and the puruṣa–prakṛti relation remains unstable.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced relation problem

The central difficulty is coordination. If Puruṣa is inactive and Prakṛti unconscious, neither seems able to initiate a relation. Sāṁkhya invokes proximity and reflection rather than physical contact, but its analogies import force, appearance or purposiveness that require further explanation.

Śaṁkara treats Sāṁkhya as *pradhāna-malla* because it is a powerful full-system rival: it explains world, causation, self, bondage and liberation without Brahman. He attacks the unconscious first cause, purposiveness without intelligence, under-explained relation and plurality of indistinguishable Puruṣas.

Sāṁkhya replies that ordered functioning need not involve deliberative planning and that Advaita replaces the contact problem with *māyā*. The strongest verdict is comparative: Śaṁkara exposes a real coordination gap, but his own system inherits a different appearance problem.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- **2023 Q5(b)**: state the independence problem, explain proximity/reflection and then present Sankara's critique.
- **2025 Q7(a)**: explain why Samkhya is the chief opponent before listing objections.
- In liberation answers, distinguish jivanmukti's residual momentum from final disembodied isolation.
- State that classical Samkhya is nirisvara; do not import Yoga's Isvara.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Bondage = aviveka and false appropriation.
- Liberation = viveka-jnana and kaivalya.
- Contact answer: proximity, reflection and analogy.
- Sankara's pressure: unconscious teleology and no intelligible relation.
- Trap: kaivalya is isolation, not Advaitic identity or divine union.

Progress: 6 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Debates, Criticisms, Traps and the Restored Doctrine Dossier

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - rival pressure points

NYAYA -> effect is new; world needs intelligent orderer
BUDDHISM -> permanent inactive witness is unnecessary
ADVAITA -> one consciousness; Prakriti cannot be ultimate
YOGA -> adds Isvara and disciplined practice
SAMKHYA -> causal continuity + irreducible witness need neither

In simple words: Samkhya is the benchmark for real transformation and strict consciousness-matter dualism. Rivals attack either its causal thesis, its many witnesses or its unexplained coordination.

Memory line: preserve exact distinctions before entering comparison.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

8. INTER-THINKER DEBATES

Debate axis	Sāṃkhya	Rival	High-yield contrast
Self	many Puruṣas	Advaita	one Ātman/Brahman vs many witnesses
Causation	satkārya + pariṇāma	Nyāya	pre-existent effect vs prāgabhāva/new beginning
World-process	rooted in Prakṛti	Buddhism	enduring material root vs dependent origination
God	nirīśvara	Yoga / Nyāya / Vedānta	no God needed vs explicit Īśvara/Brahman
Liberation	kaivalya	Advaita / Nyāya	isolation vs identity vs cessation of suffering

- **ANALYSIS:** In cross-school answers, Sāṃkhya is often the benchmark for real causation and strict consciousness–matter dualism.

9. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES

9.1 Criticism: teleology without intelligence

- CAUTION: How can unconscious Prakṛti evolve purposively for Puruṣa's sake?
- FACT: Sāṃkhya reply: purposive functioning need not involve conscious planning; the guṇa-structure itself yields ordered manifestation in the presence of Puruṣa.
- ANALYSIS: This reply preserves system-internal sufficiency but remains vulnerable to Vedāntic criticism.

9.2 Criticism: relation between two absolutes

- CAUTION: If Puruṣa and Prakṛti are radically different, how can misidentification occur?
- FACT: Sāṃkhya reply: through proximity, reflection and false attribution rather than real fusion.
- ANALYSIS: This is partly explanatory and partly analogical; critics see it as the school's weakest point.

9.3 Criticism: multiplicity of Puruṣas is unnecessary

- CAUTION: Could not one consciousness appear as many?
- FACT: Sāṃkhya reply: non-simultaneous liberation, individual experience and differentiated embodiment support plurality.

9.4 Criticism: satkāryavāda removes novelty

- CAUTION: If effect already exists, production is redundant.
- FACT: Sāṃkhya reply: production is manifestation from latent to patent, not pointless repetition.

10. COMMON UPSC TRAPS

- FACT: Mahat and buddhi are the SAME tattva — mahat is the cosmic name, buddhi is the individual/psychological name. They are NOT two separate stages.
- FACT: Kaivalya ≠ mokṣa (Advaita) ≠ apavarga (Nyāya): kaivalya = isolation/aloneness of Puruṣa; mokṣa in Advaita = identity with Brahman; apavarga in Nyāya = cessation of suffering.
- FACT: Classical Sāṃkhya is nirīśvara (atheistic) — no God. Don't confuse with theistic Yoga.
- FACT: Jīva is NOT a separate tattva — it is Puruṣa as empirically conditioned.
- FACT: Satkāryavāda is NOT unique to Sāṃkhya (Advaita also holds it) — what's unique is that Sāṃkhya's version is pariṇāmavāda (real transformation) while Advaita's is vivartavāda (apparent transformation).
- FACT: Rājasa ahaṃkāra does NOT produce a separate set of tattvas — it supplies ENERGY to both sāttvika and tāmasa lines.

11. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

11.1 Keywords

- FACT: prakṛti · pradhāna · avyakta · mūla-prakṛti · guṇa · sattva · rajas · tamas · sāmyāvasthā
- FACT: pratyakṣa · anumāna · āptavacana · śabda · sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa · sauksmya · atīndriya
- FACT: sarūpa-pariṇāma · virūpa-pariṇāma · Puruṣa · saṅghāta-parārthatvāt
- FACT: triguṇādi-viparyayāt · adhiṣṭhānāt · bhoktr-bhāvāt · kaivalyārthaṃ pravṛtteḥ
- FACT: mahat/buddhi · ahaṃkāra · manas · antaḥkaraṇa · trayodaśa-karaṇa · tanmātra · mahābhūta
- FACT: satkāryavāda · asadakaraṇāt · upādāna-grahaṇāt · sarvasambhavābhāvāt · śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt · karaṇa-bhāvāt
- FACT: pariṇāmavāda · abhivṛtya · avasthā · aviveka · viveka-jñāna · kaivalya · sānnidhya · nirīśvara · pradhāna-malla

11.2 Statement bank

- ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya is a dualist realism in which one unconscious Prakṛti evolves for the experience and liberation of many conscious Puruṣas.
- ANALYSIS: Prakṛti is inferred as the avyakta pradhāna, the unmanifest chief material principle constituted by the three guṇas.
- ANALYSIS: Puruṣa is pure consciousness — changeless, inactive and beyond the guṇas.
- ANALYSIS: Bondage is aviveka; liberation is viveka-jñāna.
- ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya's causation is satkāryavāda in the form of pariṇāmavāda.
- ANALYSIS: Śaṅkara attacks Sāṃkhya at its strongest point: its causal-metaphysical account centered on pradhāna.

<!-- restored-2018-2020-doctrine:start -->

RESTORED 2018/2020 DOCTRINE DOSSIER

Why Puruṣas are many

- FACT: Plurality is inferred from distinct births/deaths and sense-organ allotments, non-simultaneous activity, divergent guṇa-configurations and different destinies toward liberation. One witness would make individual bondage and release unintelligible.
- CAUTION: The inference moves from empirical difference to transcendental plurality; an Advaitin can argue that one consciousness appears many through limiting adjuncts.

Prakṛtipariṇāmavāda and the mango seed

- FACT: Satkāryavāda holds that the effect pre-exists latently in its material cause; production is manifestation/transformation under suitable conditions. The mango tree arises from a mango seed because a determinate causal potency—not any arbitrary effect—is present in that material continuum.
- FACT: Against Nyāya, non-being cannot be produced from sheer absence; against Advaita, transformation is real, not merely apparent.
- WRONG: Do not say the fully formed gross tree is spatially hidden inside the seed.

<!-- restored-2018-2020-doctrine:end -->

<!-- expanded-pyq-depth:start -->

CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (complete 2018–2025 audit)

- ANALYSIS: **Priority:** Primary ownership rises to 10 of 112 parts and occurs in every year.
- FACT: **Required doctrinal depth:** The restored questions require plurality of Puruṣas, a defence of Prakṛtipariṇāmavāda against Advaita and application of satkāryavāda to the mango-seed example while rejecting rival causation theories.
- WRONG: **Trap / answer consequence:** Do not confuse one Prakṛti with one Puruṣa, or say the gross tree pre-exists visibly in the seed; reconstruct latent effect, material continuity and transformation.

<!-- expanded-pyq-depth:end -->

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced debate control

The teleology objection is stronger than the simple label "atheistic": unconscious Prakriti is said to work for Purusa's experience and release. Samkhya answers through inherent guna-structure, but the language of "for the sake of" keeps purposiveness under pressure.

The plurality objection targets metaphysical individuation rather than empirical diversity. Distinct subtle bodies explain why lives differ, but do not automatically differentiate pure attributeless consciousnesses.

The restored 2018-2020 material reinforces two high-risk points: plurality of Purusas must be argued, and the mango-seed example expresses latent causal determination rather than a gross tree already present.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

Use a four-column dialectic: **rival -> exact objection -> Samkhya reply -> residual force.**

Before finalising an answer, check:

1. Prakriti is one; Purusas are many.
2. Mahat and buddhi are one tattva.
3. Rajas energizes both evolutionary lines.
4. Purusa is inactive.
5. Satkaryavada means latent pre-existence, not visible miniature presence.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Nyaya: new effect and intelligent maker.
- Buddhism: process without permanent witness.
- Advaita: one consciousness and apparent transformation.
- Yoga: Samkhya metaphysics plus Isvara and practice.
- Trap: Samkhya evolution is not Darwinian biological evolution.

Progress: 7 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Advanced Ledgers, Comparative Positioning and the Graded Verdict

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - evaluate through dependencies

```
THREE PRAMANAS
|
inference to Prakriti and Purusa
|
guna evolution + reflected consciousness
|
bondage through non-discrimination
|
kaivalya through discrimination
```

Deny one major presupposition -> several doctrines weaken together.

In simple words: Samkhya is powerful because its parts reinforce one another. Critical evaluation asks whether each supporting link—imperceptible inference, guna theory, reflection and proximity—really carries the weight assigned to it.

Memory line: test the links, not merely the labels.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

11A. PRESUPPOSITION LEDGER

Doctrine	Presupposition	What collapses if denied
Three-pramāṇa scheme	FACT: Perception, inference and reliable testimony are jointly sufficient for liberating knowledge.	ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya must either multiply pramāṇas or leave Prakṛti/Puruṣa under-justified.
Sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa inference to Prakṛti	ANALYSIS: A general correlation can justify an imperceptible material root.	ANALYSIS: The five proofs of Prakṛti become analogical guesses rather than philosophical inference.
Guṇa theory	FACT: Qualitative variety arises from proportions of sattva, rajas and tamas within one Prakṛti.	ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya loses its economical explanation of pleasure, pain, delusion and cosmic diversity.
Satkāryavāda / pariṇāmavāda	FACT: The effect pre-exists latently and production is real transformation.	ANALYSIS: The continuity between cause and effect breaks, and Nyāya-style new production becomes stronger.
Plurality of Puruṣas	ANALYSIS: Individual experience, bondage and liberation imply numerically distinct witnesses.	ANALYSIS: Liberation of one would threaten to become liberation of all, pushing the system toward Advaita.
Puruṣa's inactivity	FACT: Agency belongs to Prakṛti's evolutes, not to pure consciousness.	ANALYSIS: Bondage would become a real modification of Puruṣa and kaivalya would be impossible.
Reflection model	ANALYSIS: Insentient buddhi can appear conscious through Puruṣa's reflection.	ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya cannot explain why cognition seems conscious while mind remains jaḍa.
Kaivalya	FACT: Liberation is discriminative isolation, not union with God or Brahman.	ANALYSIS: The distinctively Sāṃkhya soteriology collapses into Yoga or Vedānta.
Nirīśvaravāda	FACT: Prakṛti and Puruṣa are sufficient to explain world, bondage and liberation.	ANALYSIS: Yoga/Nyāya/Vedānta objections that an intelligent principle is required become decisive.

11B. PŪRVAPAKṢA–SIDDHĀNTA LEDGER

Objector	Objection	Sāṃkhya reply	Residual force ANALYSIS:
Advaita / Śaṃkara	CAUTION: As chief Sāṃkhya pūrvapakṣa in the <i>Brahmasūtra-bhāṣya</i> , unconscious Prakṛti cannot act purposively, cannot cause an ordered world, and cannot relate intelligibly to inactive Puruṣa.	FACT: Prakṛti's guṇa-structure evolves in Puruṣa's presence for experience and release; relation is sānnidhya, not physical contact.	ANALYSIS: The purposiveness of a jaḍa cause and the exact relation between the two absolutes remain the strongest Vedāntic pressure points.
Nyāya	CAUTION: Asatkāryavāda is preferable; a self that neither acts nor knows is otiose; the world needs an intelligent maker.	FACT: Determinate material continuity supports satkāryavāda; cognition and agency belong to buddhi, while Puruṣa is the witness; Īśvara is unnecessary.	ANALYSIS: Nyāya's demand for an intelligent orderer remains powerful against unconscious teleology.
Buddhist	CAUTION: No permanent substance is needed; an inactive Puruṣa fails arthakriyā.	FACT: Momentary streams cannot explain a stable witness of experience; Puruṣa's efficacy is presence-for-experience, not production.	ANALYSIS: The Buddhist can still press that non-productive efficacy is not real efficacy.
Mīmāṃsā	CAUTION: The self must be a real agent for injunctions, duty and ritual responsibility to bind.	FACT: Sāṃkhya locates injunction-following in buddhi/ahaṃkāra while keeping Puruṣa untouched.	ANALYSIS: The moral subject risks becoming empirical rather than ultimate.
Yoga	CAUTION: Practical discipline benefits from Īśvara as a special puruṣa and focus of surrender.	FACT: Sāṃkhya can accept discipline without making Īśvara metaphysically necessary.	ANALYSIS: Yoga looks more religiously and practically complete for many soteriological questions.
Viśiṣṭādvaita	CAUTION: Matter and selves cannot be independent of Brahman; an unconscious Prakṛti without divine control cannot explain cosmic order.	FACT: Sāṃkhya insists that independent Prakṛti plus plural Puruṣas are sufficient for realism and liberation.	ANALYSIS: Theistic Vedānta gives a stronger account of unity, value and ordered purposiveness.

11C. INTER-SCHOOL POSITIONING

Sc ho ol	Pramāṇas	Self	Plurality/unit y	Causation	God	Bondage	Liberation	Jīvanmukti
Sā m̐k hya	FACT: Three: pratyakṣa, anumāna, śabda	FACT: Puruṣa, pure inactive consciousness	FACT: Many Puruṣas	FACT: Satkār yavāda + pariṇāmavāda	FACT: Nirīśvara	FACT: Aviveka and abhimāna through buddhi	FACT: Kaivalya by viveka-jñāna	ANALYSIS: Accepted as body continuing by prior momentum
Yo ga	FACT: Three textual pramāṇas, with practical appeal to yogi-pratyakṣa	FACT: Puruṣa	FACT: Many Puruṣas plus special Puruṣa	FACT: Sāṃkhya-like pariṇāma	FACT: Seśvara	FACT: Citta-vṛtti and kleśas	FACT: Kaivalya through aṣṭāṅga-yoga and discriminative knowledge	FACT: Strong practical account
Ny āya -Va iśe ṣik a	FACT: Four in classical Nyāya	FACT: Ātman as substance with adventitious qualities	FACT: Many selves	FACT: Asatkāryavāda / ārambhavāda	FACT: Īśvara as maker	FACT: False knowledge, doṣa and karma	FACT: Apavarga as cessation of suffering	ANALYSIS: Not central in the same way
Bu dd his m	FACT: Two in epistemological schools: pratyakṣa and anumāna	FACT: No permanent self	FACT: No eternal ātman/puruṣa	FACT: Dependent origination	FACT: No creator God	FACT: Ignorance, craving and clinging	FACT: Nirvāṇa	ANALYSIS: Interpreted differently across schools
Jai nis m	FACT: Two broad pramāṇa classes with many subtypes	FACT: Jīva as conscious substance	FACT: Many jīvas	FACT: Realism with modification	FACT: No creator God	FACT: Karmic matter binds jīva	FACT: Kevala-jñāna and release	FACT: Liberated embodied stages discussed
Mī mā ṃs ā	ANALYSIS: Five or six, depending on Prābhākara/Bhāṭṭa	FACT: Enduring self as agent/enjoyer	FACT: Many selves	FACT: Realism; no creation from nothing	FACT: Creator God not required classically	FACT: Karma and ritual obligation	FACT: Often framed as cessation/attainment through dharma	ANALYSIS: Not a central Sāṃkhya-style doctrine
Ad vait a	FACT: Six in standard Advaita	FACT: Ātman -Brahman as non-dual consciousness	FACT: Ultimately one	FACT: Satkārya orientation as vivartavāda	FACT: Īśvara at empirical level	FACT: Avidyā/superimposition	FACT: Mokṣa as Brahman-realization	FACT: Central
Viś iṣṭā dva ita	FACT: Three central: pratyakṣa, anumāna, śabda	FACT: Selves as real modes of Brahman	FACT: Many selves within qualified non-dualism	FACT: Real transformation/dependence under Brahman	FACT: Nārāyaṇa/Brahman supreme	FACT: Karma and ignorance of dependence	FACT: Service to Brahman; release without identity-collapse	FACT: Accepted in qualified form

Sāṃkhya vs Advaita on satkāryavāda. ANALYSIS: Both can be treated as satkāryavādins because both deny sheer creation from non-being; the decisive difference is **pariṇāma** versus **vivarta**. Sāṃkhya's real transformation yields dualistic realism, while Advaita's apparent transformation yields non-dual idealism/acosmic tendency.

Sāṃkhya vs Yoga. ANALYSIS: Yoga is a friendly amendment to Sāṃkhya: it retains the broad metaphysics of Prakṛti, guṇas and many Puruṣas, but adds **Īśvara**, stronger practical discipline, **Īśvara-praṇidhāna** and **yogi-pratyakṣa**; hence Sāṃkhya is nirīśvara and more theoretical, while Yoga is seśvara and more practical.

11D. CONTROLLED WESTERN COMPARISON

Comparison	Point of contact	Disanalogy / warning
Puruṣa/Prakṛti and Cartesian dualism	ANALYSIS: Both posit two irreducible principles.	ANALYSIS: Descartes' mind thinks and acts and interacts with body; Puruṣa is inactive, and relation is proximity/reflection, not causal interaction.
Guṇas and elemental/field principles	ANALYSIS: Both explain qualitative variety through proportions of a few basic factors.	ANALYSIS: Guṇas are simultaneously ontological, psychological and ethical; no exact Western analogue exists.
Satkāryavāda and Aristotle's potentiality/actuality	ANALYSIS: Both deny creation ex nihilo and treat change as actualisation of what is already possible.	ANALYSIS: Aristotle's matter is indeterminate potentiality requiring form/finality; Prakṛti contains determinate effects and unfolds without an external agent.
Prakṛti's teleology and Schopenhauer's Will	CAUTION: Both can look like unconscious purposive striving; Schopenhauer also read Indian materials.	ANALYSIS: Schopenhauer's Will is one metaphysical drive; Sāṃkhya has one Prakṛti but many Puruṣas, and liberation is discriminative separation.
Sāṃkhya evolution and Darwinian evolution	ANALYSIS: Both use the word "evolution" for ordered emergence.	FACT: UPSC trap: Sāṃkhya evolution is tattva-unfolding from a material cause, not descent with modification by natural selection.
Kaivalya and Stoic apatheia	ANALYSIS: Both involve release from passion and misidentification.	ANALYSIS: The Stoic sage remains an agent in a rational cosmos; Sāṃkhya's Puruṣa is inactive and isolated from Prakṛti.

Rubric. ANALYSIS: Western parallels are illustrative only, never a substitute for the Sāṃkhya argument; use at most one or two lines after the Indian case is complete.

11E. DIRECTIVE DECODER

Directive	What the examiner is testing	Structural move for a Sāṃkhya answer	Closing verdict
Discuss	ANALYSIS: Breadth plus ordered explanation.	ANALYSIS: State thesis -> explain doctrine -> add one debate.	ANALYSIS: "Thus Sāṃkhya offers a coherent realist account, though its relation problem remains."
Examine	ANALYSIS: Internal logic.	ANALYSIS: Give reasons/presuppositions, not just features.	ANALYSIS: "The doctrine stands if its inferential presupposition is granted."
Critically examine	ANALYSIS: Doctrine plus objections.	ANALYSIS: Exposition -> named pūrvapakṣa -> Sāṃkhya reply -> residual weakness.	ANALYSIS: "Strong as system-internal realism, vulnerable at the puruṣa–prakṛti relation."
Analyse	ANALYSIS: Components and causal links.	ANALYSIS: Break into Prakṛti, Puruṣa, guṇas, causation and liberation.	ANALYSIS: "The strength lies in how the parts mutually support one another."
Evaluate	ANALYSIS: Reasoned judgement.	ANALYSIS: Weigh explanatory gain against objections.	ANALYSIS: "More persuasive as phenomenology of consciousness than as final metaphysics."
Compare	ANALYSIS: Similarity and difference.	ANALYSIS: Use a table; compare causation, self, God, liberation.	ANALYSIS: "The decisive difference is ..."
Distinguish	ANALYSIS: Precise conceptual separation.	ANALYSIS: Define both terms and give the non-overlap.	ANALYSIS: "Confusing these terms changes the whole system."
Elucidate	ANALYSIS: Clarification through example.	ANALYSIS: Define -> illustrate -> connect to liberation/PYQ.	ANALYSIS: "The example shows the doctrine's intended force."
Comment	ANALYSIS: Short judgement on a quoted claim.	ANALYSIS: Identify claim -> support -> qualify.	ANALYSIS: "The statement is substantially correct, but incomplete without ..."
Bring out	ANALYSIS: Make implicit significance explicit.	ANALYSIS: State feature -> show why it matters for the system.	ANALYSIS: "This brings out Sāṃkhya's distinctive dualist realism."
Do you agree?	ANALYSIS: Balanced assent/dissent.	ANALYSIS: Say yes/no/partly -> argue both sides -> verdict.	ANALYSIS: "I agree only to the extent that ..."

11F. GRADED VERDICT ON SĀṂKHYA

11F.1 What is strong

- FACT: Sāṃkhya is a rigorously argued non-theistic realism rather than a loose mythology of evolution.
- FACT: Its guṇa theory is one of the most economical Indian accounts of qualitative variety.
- FACT: Satkāryavāda is a genuinely powerful causal thesis because it explains determinate production and material continuity.
- FACT: Its separation of consciousness from mental function anticipates the modern distinction between phenomenal consciousness and cognitive processing.

11F.2 What is weak

- ANALYSIS: The puruṣa–prakṛti relation is under-explained because inactive consciousness and unconscious matter must somehow generate experience.
- ANALYSIS: Unconscious teleology remains difficult: Prakṛti works "for" Puruṣa without intelligence.
- ANALYSIS: Individuation of attributeless Puruṣas is the weakest point in the plurality doctrine.
- ANALYSIS: The beginning of bondage is obscure because Puruṣa is never really modified and Prakṛti is beginningless.

11F.3 What is genuinely contested

- CAUTION: Whether early Sāṃkhya was originally theistic or consistently nirīśvara remains debated.
- CAUTION: Whether kaivalya is purely negative isolation or has a positive phenomenological character is disputed.
- CAUTION: The relation between the Kārikā tradition and later Sūtra tradition is historically and doctrinally contested.

11F.4 Ready one-line verdicts

- **10 marks.** ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya is strongest as a concise dualist realism: one Prakṛti explains the world, many Puruṣas explain experience, and viveka explains liberation.
- **15 marks.** ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya's power lies in the mutual fit of pramāṇa, satkāryavāda, guṇa theory and kaivalya, though its contact problem invites Vedāntic criticism.
- **20 marks.** ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya is a philosophically serious non-theistic system whose causal realism and psychology of reflection are impressive, but whose unconscious teleology and plurality of attributeless Puruṣas remain unresolved pressure points.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced comparative verdict

The system's strongest achievement is integration. Three-pramāṇa epistemology justifies two ultimate principles; guṇa theory links psychology and cosmology; satkāryavāda explains material continuity; reflection explains empirical consciousness; discrimination completes the soteriology.

Its weakest points are also structural. General-correlation inference may underdetermine its imperceptible entities, guṇa explanation can become too elastic, attributeless Puruṣas lack a clear individuator and proximity does not fully explain teleology.

Controlled Western parallels may illuminate but not substitute: Cartesian mind acts while Puruṣa does not; Aristotelian potentiality resembles latent effect only partially; Darwinian evolution is categorically different from tattva-unfolding.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- "Examine" requires assumptions and inferential structure.
- "Critically examine" adds a named opponent, reply and remaining weakness.
- "Compare" should use exact axes: self, plurality, causation, God, bondage and liberation.
- Best 20-mark criterion: explanatory integration versus the unresolved coordination of inactive consciousness and unconscious activity.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Strengths: causal continuity, guna integration, pure subjectivity, coherent liberation.
- Weaknesses: contact, teleology, Purusa individuation, beginningless misidentification.
- Best verdict: rigorous non-theistic dualist realism with an incomplete relation mechanism.

Progress: 8 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: PYQ Routing, Answer Architecture and Complete Exam Deployment

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - route before writing

QUESTION

|
+-- Prakriti / gunas
+-- Purusa / plurality / jiva
+-- evolution / causation
+-- liberation / relation problem
+-- Sankara critique
|

technical thesis -> ordered proof -> rival -> verdict

In simple words: the ten verified questions repeatedly test a small number of reusable doctrinal blocks. Learn the blocks deeply and adapt them to the directive and marks.

Marks	Minimum architecture
10	Definition -> proof/distinction -> one evaluation
15	Doctrine -> structure -> comparison/criticism -> verdict
20	Full derivation -> strongest rival -> reply -> graded conclusion

Memory line: exact sequence first, critical assessment second.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

12. PYQ ROUTING (2018–2025)

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** 10 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper I corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2018	Q5(e)	10 marks	Is Puruṣa one or many? Explain the Sāṃkhya position in this regard and give arguments in support of your answer.
2018	Q7(b)	15 marks	How do the Advaita Vedāntins react to the Prakṛtipariṇāma-vāda of the Sāṃkhya philosophy? How do the Sāṃkhyas defend their own position in this regard? Discuss.
2019	Q5(d)	10 marks	Critically discuss the metaphysical status of a Jīva and a Puruṣa according to Sāṃkhya philosophy.
2019	Q8(c)	15 marks	Which Sāṃkhya proof for the existence of Prakṛti actually shows that there can be only one Prakṛti? Justify your answer.
2020	Q7(a)	20 marks	"A mango tree is grown out of a mango seed." How will Sāṃkhya system explain this process through their theory of causation by rejecting their rival perspectives?

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2021	Q6(b)	15 marks	Explain the Sāṃkhya view on three guṇas (guṇa-traya) and their modifications.
2022	Q5(a)	10 marks	Examine and evaluate the proofs given by Sāṃkhya philosophy to prove the existence of Puruṣa.
2023	Q5(b)	10 marks	"If Puruṣa and Prakṛti are two completely independent realities, then no relation between the two is possible." In the light of this statement make a brief presentation of Śaṅkara's criticism of Sāṃkhya dualism.
2024	Q7(a)	20 marks (10+10)	Present an account of evolution of Prakṛti as propounded in Sāṃkhyakārikā. In this context, also explain the difference between buddhi, mahat and ahaṃkāra.
2025	Q7(a)	20 marks	Why does Śaṅkara consider Sāṃkhya Philosophy as his chief opponent (pradhāna malla)? Examine his arguments against Sāṃkhya Philosophy.

See the Indian Philosophy PYQ Bank, 2018–2025.

13. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

13.1 10-mark format

- ANALYSIS: Start with the technical thesis in one line.
- ANALYSIS: Give the numbered proof / sequence / distinction directly.
- ANALYSIS: Add one contrast or objection.
- ANALYSIS: End with a judgement tied to the directive word.

13.2 15-mark format

- ANALYSIS: Frame the doctrinal problem in 2-3 lines.
- ANALYSIS: Expose the doctrine in ordered points.
- ANALYSIS: Add distinction, comparison or criticism required by the question.
- ANALYSIS: End with one reasoned verdict.

13.3 20-mark format

- ANALYSIS: Frame Sāṃkhya as a full metaphysical system, not a school-summary.
- ANALYSIS: Body A: full doctrine in sequence.
- ANALYSIS: Body B: strongest rival or criticism.
- ANALYSIS: Body C: reply and evaluation.
- ANALYSIS: End with a philosophical conclusion, not a slogan.

13.4 Ready skeletons

Proofs for Puruṣa

Define Puruṣa as pure consciousness distinct from the guṇas.

List: saṅghāta-parārthatvāt, triguṇādi-viparyayāt, adhiṣṭhānāt, bhoktṛ-bhāvāt, kaivalyārthaṃ pravṛtते.

Evaluate their cumulative force.

Close: experience and liberation presuppose a witness-self.

Evolution of Prakṛti

Start with guṇa-equilibrium in avyakta Prakṛti.

Narrate: Prakṛti → mahat/buddhi → ahaṃkāra → sāttvika and tāmasa lines; rajas energizes both.

Clarify that mahat and buddhi are one tattva.

Close with the psychological-cosmological unity of the scheme.

Śaṃkara as critic

State Sāṃkhya dualism briefly.

Raise the contact problem.

Show why unconscious pradhāna cannot be the Upaniṣadic cause.

Conclude why Sāṃkhya is the chief but rejected rival.

14. LINK-OUTS

- Yoga — shared metaphysics + Īśvara addition
- Vedānta — pariṇāma vs vivarta; Śaṃkara's critique
- Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika — asatkāryavāda contrast
- Causation across schools
- Self and liberation
- Pramāṇa across schools
- Notions of God
- PYQ Bank
- Master Framework

SOURCES

- Īśvarakṛṣṇa, *Sāṃkhya-kārikā*.
- S. Chatterjee & D. Datta, *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*.
- C.D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*.
- S. Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy* vol. 2.
- Vācaspati Miśra, *Sāṃkhya-tattva-kaumudī*.

CURRENT LINKAGE STATUS

FACT: **Search result, 16 August 2026:** No reliable official development specifically applying or revising Samkhya doctrine was verified for February-August 2026. A web result claiming adoption of a national "Samkhya Paradigm" in mental-health policy was not supported by an official government source and is excluded. Broad Indian Knowledge Systems activity is context only, not doctrinal evidence.

Direct local source anchors

- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta, local OCR edition, especially file pages 205-216: satkaryavada, Prakriti, gunas, Purusa and evolution.
- FACT: C. D. Sharma, local OCR edition, especially file pages 149-159: causation, one Prakriti, three gunas, Purusa, contact problem and evolutes.
- FACT: The repository PYQ bank controls wording, marks and ownership for all ten solved questions.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced corpus strategy

The 2018-2025 corpus moves systematically through plurality, causal transformation, jiva, one Prakriti, gunas, proofs of Purusa, the contact problem, full evolution and Sankara's critique. This rewards modular revision rather than ten unrelated essays.

The fresh 2026 search again surfaced an unsupported claim that the Ministry of Health adopted a national "Samkhya Paradigm." No official source verified it, so it remains excluded. Broad Indian Knowledge Systems activity is educational context only and does not prove or revise classical doctrine.

Use the final register notes only after the solved PYQs and practice loops; they are a consolidation tool, not a replacement for derivation and debate.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

The complete practice section contains:

- **10 verified solved PYQs** from 2018-2025.
- **24 integrated MCQs** and **8 remedial MCQs**.
- Original 10-, 15- and 20-mark questions with model solutions.
- Final consolidated register notes after all teaching and practice.

Attempt first, compare with the model second, then rewrite the weak section under time.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall - master route

Prompt	Recall spine
Epistemology	three pramanas and samanyato-drsta inference
Prakriti	five proofs, three gunas, one root
Purusa	five proofs, plurality and jiva distinction
Evolution	Prakriti -> mahat/buddhi -> ahamkara -> two lines
Causation	latent effect and real transformation
Liberation	aviveka -> viveka -> kaivalya
Critique	inactive witness + unconscious teleology

PART II - SOLVED PYQs, PRACTICE AND ANSWER TRAINING

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q5(e), 10 marks

Question: Is Purusa one or many? Explain the Samkhya position and arguments.

Model solution

Samkhya accepts **many Purusas**. Each Purusa is eternal, inactive, attributeless pure consciousness, but numerical plurality is required to explain differences among embodied streams.

The standard arguments are:

1. **Separate births and deaths:** one organism begins or ends without all doing so.
2. **Non-simultaneous activity:** when one sleeps, another acts.
3. **Diversity of experience:** pleasure, pain and knowledge differ among persons.
4. **Moral individuality:** karmic fruits attach to distinct empirical streams.
5. **Non-simultaneous liberation:** one person's release does not liberate all.

Advaita objects that attributeless consciousness cannot be numerically differentiated; apparent plurality may arise from distinct adjuncts. Samkhya replies that if only one Purusa existed, bondage and liberation would become universally simultaneous.

Verdict: Plurality protects moral and soteriological individuality, though the principle distinguishing qualitatively identical Purusas remains under-explained.

Why this earns marks: It states the position, gives five arguments, adds the Advaita objection and reaches a qualified conclusion.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: How do Advaita Vedantins react to Prakritiparinamavada, and how does Samkhya defend itself?

Model solution

Samkhya holds that Prakriti really transforms into the world. The effect pre-exists in the cause and becomes manifest through **parinama**. Advaita accepts satkaryavada at a broad level but rejects independent unconscious Prakriti and real transformation of ultimate reality.

Sankara's objections are:

1. An unconscious pradhana cannot initiate purposive, ordered evolution.
2. If Purusa is inactive and Prakriti independent, their relation is unintelligible.
3. The Upanisads present an intelligent principle, not unconscious matter, as world-ground.
4. Real transformation would compromise the changelessness of ultimate reality.
5. Two independent absolutes leave their coordination unexplained.

Advaita therefore proposes **vivartavada**: the world is an appearance of Brahman through maya, not a real transformation of Brahman.

Samkhya replies that effects share the guna-structure of their cause and require material continuity. Milk changes into curd without an external intelligent planner; similarly Prakriti's inherent tendency and Purusa's proximity suffice. A God does not explain how consciousness creates unconscious matter, whereas Prakriti naturally contains the material potency of the world.

Verdict: Samkhya explains real causal continuity better; Advaita presses the deeper problem of how unconscious teleology and dual coordination are possible.

Why this earns marks: It presents both schools symmetrically, distinguishes parinama from vivarta, and evaluates the material-continuity versus intelligence dispute.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question: Critically discuss the metaphysical status of Jiva and Purusa.

Model solution

Purusa is pure, eternal, inactive consciousness—witness, not agent or product. **Jiva** is Purusa apparently associated with the subtle body, buddhi, ahamkara, manas, senses and karmic dispositions.

Purusa	Jiva
pure consciousness	empirical embodied subject
inactive witness	appears as knower, doer, enjoyer
unbound in itself	subject to bondage and transmigration
plural and eternal	psychophysical stream around one Purusa

Buddhi is material but sattva-predominant and reflects consciousness. Ahamkara appropriates this reflected awareness as "I know" and "I act." Bondage belongs strictly to Prakriti's apparatus, yet is attributed to Purusa through non-discrimination.

The criticism is severe: if Purusa is never really bound, liberation appears unnecessary; if Jiva alone is bound, it is unclear who seeks release. Samkhya replies that liberation removes false identification, not a real modification of Purusa.

Why this earns marks: It gives the precise distinction, explains reflection and false appropriation, and identifies the paradox of an eternally free Purusa.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2019 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question: Which proof for Prakriti establishes that there can be only one Prakriti?

Model solution

The decisive proof is **avibhagat vaisvarupyasya**: the differentiated universe points to an undivided source. The cosmos displays immense plurality but also systemic unity and reciprocal transformation. Its differentiated forms must emerge from one unmanifest matrix in which they are not yet divided.

The other proofs establish the need for a material ground:

- *bhedanam parimanat*: finite effects require a ground.
- *samanvayat*: common guna-structure suggests a common cause.
- *karyatah pravrtteh*: productive activity presupposes potency.
- *karana-karya-vibhagat*: manifest effect differs from unmanifest causal state.

These support Prakriti's existence, but they do not as directly exclude multiple root causes. The fifth proof specifically moves from unified diversification to one undivided source.

An opponent may argue that cosmic coordination does not logically prove numerical unity; several coordinated causes are possible. Samkhya replies that multiple Prakritis with the same guna-constitution are explanatorily redundant and would require a higher principle coordinating them.

Verdict: The proof is abductive rather than demonstrative: one Prakriti is the most economical common material explanation of an interconnected guna-world.

Why this earns marks: It identifies the exact proof, distinguishes it from the other four and justifies both its force and limitation.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2020 Q7(a), 20 marks

Question: A mango tree grows from a mango seed. Explain through Samkhya causation while rejecting rivals.

Model solution

Samkhya explains the mango tree through **satkaryavada**: the effect exists latently in its material cause before manifestation. The seed is not an actual miniature tree, but it contains the determinate material potency that can unfold into that tree under suitable conditions.

Five arguments support the doctrine:

1. **Asadakaranat**: what is absolutely non-existent cannot be produced.
2. **Upadana-grahanat**: production requires a specific material cause.
3. **Sarvasambhavabhavat**: everything cannot arise from everything.
4. **Saktasya sakya-karanat**: a cause produces only what lies within its capacity.
5. **Karana-bhavat**: effect retains the nature of the cause.

The seed-to-tree process is **parinamavada**, real transformation. Production is manifestation; destruction is return to an unmanifest condition. Soil, water and heat are auxiliaries, while the seed carries mango-specific causal power.

Nyaya's asatkaryavada says the tree is newly produced and had prior absence. Samkhya objects that if wholly absent, its production from this rather than any cause is unintelligible. Nyaya replies that capacity, not latent effect, limits production.

Buddhist dependent origination treats seed and tree as momentary causal series without enduring material identity. Samkhya argues that a shared substrate and continuity better explain determinate transformation.

Advaita vivartavada treats worldly transformation as appearance relative to Brahman. Samkhya insists the empirical world and its changes are real and require real material evolution.

Verdict: Satkaryavada powerfully explains specificity and continuity, though critics may say it redescribes capacity as pre-existence and weakens genuine novelty.

Why this earns marks: It applies all five arguments to the example, distinguishes real transformation, and answers Nyaya, Buddhist and Advaita rivals.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 Q6(b), 15 marks

Question: Explain the three gunas and their modifications.

Model solution

Prakriti consists of **sattva, rajas and tamas**, not as qualities added to a substance but as its constitutive strands.

Guna	Character	Psychological expression	Physical tendency
Sattva	illumination, lightness	clarity, pleasure, knowledge	upward/light
Rajas	activity, stimulation	desire, effort, restlessness	motion
Tamas	restraint, heaviness	ignorance, dullness, obstruction	inertia/downward

They are mutually opposed yet cooperative, like oil, wick and flame. Every product contains all three in different proportions.

In primordial Prakriti they undergo **sarupa-parinama**, homogeneous internal change that preserves equilibrium. Purusa's proximity disturbs balance and produces **virupa-parinama**, heterogeneous predominance initiating evolution. Rajas activates; sattva and tamas differentiate into cognitive and material lines.

Modification never creates substance from nothing. Each tattva is a new configuration of the same guna-material. This grounds both cosmology and psychology: knowledge, desire, inertia, senses and elements are stages of one material evolution.

Verdict: Guna theory unifies mind and matter without reducing one to the other, but it risks explaining diverse phenomena through highly elastic principles.

Why this earns marks: It gives nature, cooperation, two forms of modification and the cosmological-psychological payoff.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2022 Q5(a), 10 marks

Question: Examine and evaluate the proofs for Purusa.

Model solution

Samkhya gives five cumulative proofs:

1. **Sanghata-pararthatvat:** aggregates exist for another; body-mind serves a conscious subject.
2. **Trigunadi-viparyayat:** the witness must be opposite to the changing, unconscious gunas.
3. **Adhistanat:** organized experience requires a presiding consciousness.
4. **Bhoktr-bhavat:** pleasure and pain require an experiencer.
5. **Kaivalyartham pravrtteh:** striving for liberation presupposes a liberable witness.

The arguments jointly distinguish the objectifiable psychophysical apparatus from a non-objective subject. They are strongest phenomenologically: experience seems to require a standpoint not reducible to what is experienced.

Buddhists deny that aggregates exist "for" a separate owner and explain experience as a causal stream. Advaita accepts witness-consciousness but denies its plurality.

Verdict: The proofs establish a subject-pole more plausibly than they establish many eternal, wholly inactive Purusas. Their cumulative force exceeds each argument taken alone.

Why this earns marks: It lists all five technical proofs and distinguishes proof of consciousness from proof of Samkhya's full pluralist ontology.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2023 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: Present Sankara's criticism that no relation is possible between independent Purusa and Prakriti.

Model solution

Sankara argues that Samkhya's two independent principles cannot initiate a coordinated world-process. Purusa is inactive and changeless; Prakriti is unconscious. Neither can intentionally approach, affect or know the other.

If proximity is a real relation, both principles undergo relational modification and lose absolute independence. If proximity is unreal, it cannot explain the disturbance of guna-equilibrium. If it is beginningless, evolution should be continuous and liberation impossible.

The lame-and-blind analogy assumes cooperation but does not explain its ground: the lame person consciously directs the blind, whereas Purusa cannot act and Prakriti cannot understand.

Samkhya replies that proximity is not physical contact but reflective presence. A magnet moves iron without changing itself, and Prakriti operates for Purusa like milk flowing for the calf.

Verdict: The analogies clarify non-mechanical influence but do not fully explain how two independent absolutes enter a purposive relation.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs Sankara's dilemma, tests Samkhya's analogies and gives a concise evaluation.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2024 Q7(a), 20 marks

Question: Explain evolution of Prakriti and distinguish buddhi, mahat and ahamkara.

Model solution

Evolution begins when the equilibrium of sattva, rajas and tamas in avyakta Prakriti is disturbed in the presence of Purusa.

Prakriti
↓
Mahat / Buddhi
↓
Ahamkara
+- sattvika line -> manas + 5 cognitive senses + 5 action senses
+- tamasa line -> 5 tanmatras -> 5 gross elements
+- rajas -> energizes both lines

Together with Prakriti and Purusa, the evolutes form twenty-five tattvas.

Mahat is the first cosmic evolute—the "great" principle of determination in the universal process. **Buddhi** is the same tattva viewed psychologically as individual determinative intellect; it performs adhyavasaya, judgement and discrimination. Thus mahat and buddhi are not two separate tattvas.

Ahamkara is the next evolute, the I-maker that appropriates experience as "I" and "mine." From its sattvika aspect arise the eleven faculties; from its tamasa aspect arise five subtle elements. Rajas supplies activity.

Buddhi is material, not consciousness. Its sattva-like transparency reflects Purusa, creating the appearance of a conscious intellect. Ahamkara misappropriates reflected consciousness and generates bondage.

Critics question how mere proximity initiates evolution and how unconscious Prakriti acts purposively. Samkhya replies that transformation is inherent in the gunas and serves the dual ends of experience and liberation.

Verdict: The scheme unifies cosmology and psychology with remarkable economy, though its first transition from independent Purusa to disturbed Prakriti remains the weakest link.

Why this earns marks: It provides the full sequence, correctly equates mahat and buddhi at two levels, distinguishes ahamkara and adds philosophical evaluation.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2025 Q7(a), 20 marks

Question: Why does Sankara call Samkhya his chief opponent, pradhana malla? Examine his arguments.

Model solution

Samkhya is Advaita's chief opponent because it offers the strongest systematic rival account of one world-ground, causation, bondage and liberation. Both seek an ultimate explanation beneath plurality and accept that ignorance causes bondage, but Samkhya proposes unconscious Pradhana and many Purusas where Advaita proposes non-dual Brahman.

Sankara's principal criticisms are:

1. **Scriptural:** Upanisadic causation passages describe an intelligent knowing source, not unconscious Pradhana.
2. **Teleological:** unconscious Prakriti cannot produce an ordered world for experience and liberation.
3. **Contact problem:** inactive Purusa and independent Prakriti cannot enter an intelligible relation.
4. **Analogy failure:** milk-calf and lame-blind examples presuppose structures absent from the two principles.
5. **Plurality problem:** qualitatively identical, attributeless Purusas lack a differentiating principle.
6. **Causal criticism:** real transformation of the ultimate threatens its independence; Advaita prefers apparent transformation.
7. **Bondage paradox:** an eternally inactive witness cannot really be bound or liberated.

Samkhya replies that material continuity requires Prakriti; the gunas explain mind and matter; plurality protects individual karma; and intelligence need not plan natural transformation. Advaita, in turn, must explain how maya and appearance arise without compromising Brahman.

Sankara treats Samkhya seriously because it cannot be dismissed as crude materialism. It shares renunciatory and discriminative aims, supplies a mature causal theory, and deeply influenced the conceptual vocabulary of Indian thought.

Verdict: Sankara's strongest objection is not mere scriptural disagreement but explanatory coordination: Samkhya cannot fully show how an unconscious independent cause evolves for an inactive independent consciousness. Yet Advaita replaces this with its own maya problem.

Why this earns marks: It explains the title pradhana malla, gives seven arguments, includes Samkhya's defence and offers a comparative final judgement.

Integrated MCQ Loop - 24 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
1	Samkhya admits: A. three pramanas B. one pramana C. four pramanas D. six pramanas	A	Perception, inference and reliable testimony.
2	The decisive inference for imperceptible Prakriti and Purusa is: A. purvavat B. samanyato-drsta C. sesavat D. kevalanvayi	B	It reaches entities not ordinarily perceived.
3	Prakriti is: A. conscious and many B. inactive witness C. one, unconscious and trigunatmaka D. created by God	C	It is the single unmanifest material root.
4	Purusa is: A. material intellect B. active creator C. guna-composite D. pure inactive consciousness	D	Purusa witnesses but does not transform.
5	The proof indicating one Prakriti is: A. avibhagat vaisvarupyasya B. adhisthanat C. bhoktr-bhavat D. asadakaranat	A	Unified diversity points to one undivided source.
6	Sattva primarily denotes: A. inertia B. illumination C. activity D. gross matter	B	Sattva manifests lightness, clarity and knowledge.
7	Rajas primarily supplies: A. obscuration B. equilibrium C. activity D. consciousness	C	It energizes both evolutionary lines.
8	Tamas primarily denotes: A. pleasure B. witnesshood C. inference D. inertia and obstruction	D	Tamas restrains and conceals.
9	Homogeneous guna-modification is: A. sarupa-parinama B. virupa-parinama C. vivarta D. arambha	A	Gunas internally change while equilibrium remains.
10	Heterogeneous transformation begins with: A. liberation B. disturbance of equilibrium C. destruction of Purusa D. divine creation	B	Unequal predominance initiates manifest evolution.
11	First evolute of Prakriti is: A. manas B. ahamkara C. mahat/buddhi D. akasa	C	Mahat is cosmic, buddhi psychological aspect.
12	Ahamkara is: A. pure consciousness B. gross element C. final liberation D. I-maker and appropriation principle	D	It turns reflected consciousness into "I" and "mine."
13	Satkaryavada holds: A. effect pre-exists in cause B. effect is wholly new C. causation is unreal D. God creates ex nihilo	A	Production is manifestation of latent effect.
14	Asadakaranat means: A. every cause is conscious B. non-being cannot be produced C. effects are illusory D. atoms are eternal	B	Absolute non-existence cannot become an effect.
15	Samkhya's causal transformation is: A. vivartavada B. arambhavada C. parinamavada D. sunyavada	C	The material cause really transforms.
16	Purusa plurality explains: A. one cosmic body B. universal simultaneous liberation C. one karmic stream D. diverse births, experiences and liberation	D	Individuality requires many witnesses.
17	Sanghata-pararthatvat argues from: A. aggregates existing for another B. scriptural testimony C. atomic combination D. absence	A	Composite instruments imply a conscious beneficiary.
18	Bhoktr-bhavat proves Purusa from: A. creation B. experience requiring an enjoyer C. universal cognition D. linguistic convention	B	Pleasure and pain require a subject.
19	Kaivalya results from: A. ritual action B. divine grace alone C. discriminative knowledge D. destruction of Prakriti	C	Viveka separates witness from material process.

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
20	Bondage is fundamentally: A. a real change in Purusa B. God's punishment C. bodily existence only D. non-discrimination and false identification	D	Purusa mistakes Prakriti's operations for its own.
21	Lame-blind analogy explains: A. cooperation of inactive consciousness and unconscious activity B. three pramanas C. Vedic authority D. atomism	A	Each supplies what the other lacks.
22	Sankara's chief criticism targets: A. guna enumeration B. relation and teleology between independent principles C. absence theory D. testimony	B	Coordination of inactive Purusa and unconscious Prakriti is obscure.
23	Jiva is: A. identical with gross body B. a fourth guna C. Purusa apparently associated with subtle body and intellect D. creator God	C	Empirical subject arises through reflection and identification.
24	Samkhya is classically: A. nihilistic B. monistic C. theistic creationism D. realist dualism and nirisvara soteriology	D	It needs no creator God for liberation or evolution.

Remedial MCQ Loop - 8 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
25	Mahat and buddhi are: A. one tattva viewed cosmically and psychologically B. separate eternal realities C. two gunas D. names of Purusa	A	Mahat is cosmic determination; buddhi its individual function.
26	The sattvika line from ahamkara produces: A. gross elements B. mind and ten faculties C. Prakriti D. Purusa	B	Manas, five cognitive and five action faculties arise.
27	The tamasa line produces: A. Purusas B. only ahamkara C. tanmatras and gross elements D. liberation	C	Subtle elements evolve into gross elements.
28	Why is Samkhya not crude materialism? A. it denies matter B. it accepts God C. it treats senses as eternal souls D. it admits irreducible pure consciousness	D	Purusa is distinct from material Prakriti.
29	Strongest defence of satkaryavada is: A. determinate causes produce determinate effects B. every effect is perceived before production C. God reveals causes D. nothing changes	A	Causal specificity supports latent capacity/effect.
30	Advaita differs by accepting: A. many independent Prakritis B. vivarta rather than real transformation of ultimate reality C. atomic creation D. Buddhist momentariness	B	World appearance does not transform Brahman.
31	The contact problem asks: A. how senses touch objects B. how gunas mix C. how inactive Purusa and independent Prakriti coordinate D. how words signify	C	Dualism lacks a clear relation mechanism.
32	Best verdict: A. Samkhya is only cosmology B. Purusa creates Prakriti C. liberation requires destroying the world D. Samkhya unifies causal realism and psychology but struggles with unconscious teleology	D	This captures strength and central weakness.

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Why is Samkhya epistemology indispensable to its metaphysics?

Model solution

Prakriti and Purusa are atindriya and cannot be perceived. Samkhya therefore restricts valid knowledge to perception, inference and testimony, then relies chiefly on samanyato-drsta inference to establish its two ultimate realities.

Manifest effects, guna-patterns and causal dependence support Prakriti; objectifiable aggregates, experience and striving for liberation support Purusa. Without this inferential bridge, the system would merely assert invisible entities.

Verdict: Samkhya metaphysics is an inferential construction constrained by its pramana theory, though critics dispute whether general correlation can prove wholly imperceptible realities.

Why this earns marks: It links epistemology directly to the proof burden for both ultimate principles.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 15 marks

Question: Does guna theory successfully unify Samkhya cosmology and psychology?

Model solution

The three gunas constitute every material and mental product. Sattva explains illumination and pleasure; rajas activity and desire; tamas inertia and obscuration. Their varying proportions explain physical, cognitive and affective diversity.

Cosmologically, guna disequilibrium generates the twenty-three evolutes. Psychologically, sattva-dominant buddhi reflects consciousness, rajas drives action and tamas obstructs discrimination. Thus mind and matter are continuous expressions of Prakriti rather than separate substances.

The theory's strength is explanatory unity. Its weakness is elasticity: almost any phenomenon can be redescribed as a guna mixture, making independent testing difficult.

Verdict: Guna theory is architecturally successful but evidentially underdetermined; it unifies the system more convincingly than it proves its three constituents.

Why this earns marks: It tests the doctrine against both domains and distinguishes explanatory integration from empirical proof.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 20 marks

Question: "Samkhya makes consciousness metaphysically pure by making agency philosophically obscure." Critically examine.

Model solution

Samkhya sharply distinguishes Purusa from every objectifiable feature. Consciousness is not body, sense, mind, ego or intellect; it is the changeless witness illuminating them. This protects subjectivity from reduction to unconscious Prakriti.

The cost is agency. Purusa cannot act, while buddhi acts but is unconscious. Empirical cognition is explained through reflection of Purusa in sattva-dominant buddhi; ahankara appropriates the result. The jiva therefore appears to know and act although its conscious pole is inactive and its active pole is non-conscious.

This division helps explain bondage as misidentification and liberation as discrimination. It also supports moral continuity through the subtle body. Yet it raises the contact problem: how can reflected consciousness arise, why does Prakriti evolve for Purusa, and who genuinely strives for liberation?

Samkhya analogies—magnet and iron, lame and blind, dancer and spectator—show asymmetric cooperation without material fusion. Critics answer that each analogy imports causal or intentional relations denied to the two principles.

Advaita solves the split by making consciousness the sole reality but inherits the problem of maya. Buddhist process theory rejects a witness but struggles with ownership. Samkhya's dualism therefore isolates a real philosophical datum even if its mechanism is incomplete.

Verdict: The statement is substantially correct. Samkhya gives one of Indian philosophy's clearest accounts of pure subjectivity, but its separation of consciousness from activity makes empirical agency and teleology its deepest unresolved problems.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates the trade-off, uses cognition and liberation mechanisms, tests analogies, compares rivals and reaches a balanced verdict.

FINAL CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES - SAMKHYA

Core Formula

ONE PRAKRITI + MANY PURUSAS
THREE GUNAS + TWENTY-FIVE TATTVAS
SATKARYAVADA + PARINAMAVADA
AVIVEKA -> BONDAGE
VIVEKA-JNANA -> KAIVALYA

Epistemology

- Three pramanas: perception, inference, testimony.
- Samanyato-drsta inference proves imperceptible Prakriti and Purusa.
- Buddhi determines, ahamkara appropriates, manas coordinates.
- Consciousness appears in buddhi through reflection.

Prakriti

- One, eternal, unmanifest, unconscious material root.
- Also pradhana and avyakta.
- Five proofs: parimana, samanvaya, productive activity, cause-effect distinction, unified diversity.
- Avibhagat vaisvarupyasya best supports one Prakriti.

Three Gunas

Guna	Core	Mental expression
Sattva	illumination	clarity, pleasure
Rajas	activity	desire, restlessness
Tamas	restraint	ignorance, inertia

- Sarupa-parinama: equilibrium-preserving change.
- Virupa-parinama: disequilibrium and evolution.

Purusa

- Pure, inactive, eternal, plural consciousness.
- Five proofs: aggregate-for-another, opposite of gunas, presiding witness, experiencer, liberation-striving.
- Plurality: separate births, actions, experiences, karma and liberation.
- Pressure: identical attributeless Purusas lack clear individuation.

Evolution

Prakriti

- > Mahat/Buddhi
- > Ahamkara
- > sattvika: manas + 10 faculties
- > tamasa: 5 tanmatras -> 5 gross elements
- > rajas energizes both

- Mahat and buddhi are one tattva at cosmic and psychological levels.
- Ahamkara is I-maker, not pure consciousness.

Causation

- Satkaryavada: effect exists latently in cause.
- Five proofs: non-being cannot arise; specific material; not everything from everything; capacity; effect has cause-nature.
- Parinamavada: cause really transforms.
- Nyaya: effect is new.
- Advaita: transformation is appearance.
- Buddhism: momentary dependent process.

Liberation

- Bondage = avidya and abhimana.
- Kaivalya = discriminative knowledge that Purusa is not Prakriti.
- Prakriti ceases display for the discriminating Purusa.
- Jivanmukti continues until prior momentum ends; videhamukti follows.
- No creator God is required.

Sankara Critique

- Unconscious cause cannot act purposively.
- Inactive Purusa cannot coordinate Prakriti.
- Real relation compromises independence; unreal relation explains nothing.
- Analogies assume missing intelligence or causality.
- Upanisadic cause is conscious.
- Many Purusas are under-differentiated.
- Advaita's counter-pressure: maya remains its own problem.

PYQ Route Map

- 2018: many Purusas; Advaita on parinamavada.
- 2019: jiva-Purusa; proof of one Prakriti.
- 2020: mango seed and satkaryavada.
- 2021: gunas and modifications.
- 2022: proofs for Purusa.
- 2023: contact problem and Sankara.
- 2024: full evolution; mahat-buddhi-ahamkara.
- 2025: Samkhya as pradhana malla.

Final Traps

1. Prakriti is one; Purusas are many.
2. Gunas are constituents, not optional qualities.
3. Buddhi is material and unconscious.
4. Mahat and buddhi are not separate tattvas.
5. Ahamkara is not Purusa.
6. Satkaryavada is not a miniature-effect theory.
7. Parinama is real transformation, unlike vivarta.
8. Purusa does not create or act.
9. Kaivalya is discrimination, not union.
10. Samkhya's chief weakness is coordination of inactive consciousness and unconscious activity.